

Foe



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF J. M. COETZEE

J. M. Coetzee was born in South Africa, where he grew up during the height of racial apartheid; though his parents were Dutch and part of the larger Afrikaner community, Coetzee spoke English at home. After graduating from the University of Cape Town, Coetzee moved to the UK, where he supported himself as a computer programmer while writing an English master's thesis. Coetzee then traveled to America for additional graduate study, eventually getting a professorship in upstate New York in 1968. Coetzee began writing around this time, publishing his first novel in 1974 and rising to international prominence in 1980 with [Waiting for the Barbarians](#), a novel about the evils of colonialism. While teaching literature in Cape Town and across the U.S., Coetzee continued to write prolifically, publishing novels like *The Life and Times of Michael K* and [Disgrace](#) as well as several lightly fictionalized memoirs. In 2002, Coetzee moved to Australia, where he currently resides. He was awarded the 2003 Nobel Prize in Literature in 2003.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Much of Coetzee's work deals explicitly with anti-colonialism and exploitation, which is no surprise given the shaping force of apartheid on his life. "Apartheid" refers to a series of segregationist laws in South Africa that were in place from 1948 to 1994; under apartheid, Black people were forcibly removed from their homes, barred from voting, and restricted from use of most public spaces. One of the major ways in which white South Africans maintained their rule was by enforcing the use of Afrikaans as an official language, even though many Black South Africans did not know it. Friday's racialized silence thus has extra layers of meanings in this apartheid context, especially since Coetzee was always a vocal advocate against his government's violence and segregation. *Foe* was published in 1986, at the height of national uprisings against apartheid; some critics hailed it as an important work of protest, while others were frustrated that it was not explicit enough in its critique.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Though *Foe* rewrites the narrative of Daniel Defoe's 1719 book [Robinson Crusoe](#)—widely considered to be the first real novel ever written—there are several major plot differences in the two narratives. While Susan Barton is the narrator and protagonist of Coetzee's work, no such character ever appears

in Defoe's novel. Though the island in [Robinson Crusoe](#) is full of cannibals and mutinies, the island Susan describes is empty and monotonous. And while author Daniel Defoe is not present in his 1719 novel, "Mr. Foe" is the titular character of *Foe*, which is focused primarily on who gets to claim ownership of what stories. *Foe* also stands alongside other postmodern, postcolonial revisions of classic texts, namely Jean Rhys's [Wide Sargasso Sea](#) and Maryse Condé's *I, Tituba*.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** *Foe*
- **When Written:** 1980s
- **Where Written:** Cape Town, South Africa
- **When Published:** 1986
- **Literary Period:** Post-modernism
- **Genre:** Novel
- **Setting:** A deserted island in the Atlantic; the various London residencies of author Daniel Defoe
- **Climax:** Against Susan Barton's wishes to be the sole narrator of her time as a castaway, Mr. Foe tries to teach Susan's servant Friday to write.
- **Antagonist:** Daniel Defoe
- **Point of View:** Susan Barton is the novel's first-person narrator until the final section, which breaks with the straightforward narrative to hover more ambiguously between Susan's and Friday's perspectives.

EXTRA CREDIT

Bonkers for Bookers. Coetzee was awarded England's prestigious Booker Prize twice, first in 1983 for *The Life and Times of Michael K* and then again in 1999 for *Disgrace*. The win for [Disgrace](#) made Coetzee the first writer in history to have two Booker prizes (and to top it all off, he was shortlisted for the prize again in 2009 for his fictionalized memoir *Summertime*).

Coetzee and Costello. A character named Elizabeth Costello appears in three Coetzee novels (including the 2003 book *Elizabeth Costello*). Interestingly, just like Coetzee rewrites [Robinson Crusoe](#) from a woman's perspective, the fictional Costello is famous for rewriting classics from the point of view of female characters. This similarity, along with the fact that both Coetzee and Costello live in Australia and are celebrated academics, has led many critics to believe that Elizabeth Costello is a fictional, literary alter-ego for Coetzee.



PLOT SUMMARY

It's the early 1700s, and Susan Barton, an Englishwoman, has just been stranded on an island in the Atlantic Ocean. Though she at first believes the **island** to be deserted, Susan quickly encounters an older white man named Cruso and his Black servant, Friday, the sole survivors of a long-ago shipwreck. Susan laments her bad fortune to an unnamed reader: after two years spent in Bahia, Brazil, trying to find her kidnapped daughter, she had at last booked passage on a ship back to Europe—only to have the ship's crew mutiny, killing the captain and casting her onto this island.

Though Cruso and Friday have built a sturdy encampment, Susan has trouble adjusting to life on the island. Cruso is gruff and rarely speaks, and Friday never talks at all; to Susan's horror, she learns that he has had his **tongue** cut out under mysterious circumstances. Worst of all, the days are monotonous: the wind won't stop howling, and all Cruso and Friday ever do is build **terraces** on the island, even though they have no crops to plant on the terraces.

After about a year, Cruso becomes deathly ill, getting feverish and delusional. For 12 days, Susan tends to Cruso while Friday distances himself, playing his flute non-stop. As Cruso's fever breaks, he and Susan have a single sexual encounter, which Susan engages in more out of pity than desire. While Cruso struggles to shake his illness, a passing British ship discovers the islanders. Susan is elated and jumps on board, but Friday is more hesitant (and Cruso, still not in his right mind, does not even realize they are being rescued). Susan takes the name Mrs. Cruso to avoid a scandal—but Cruso dies before the ship can arrive in England.

Upon her arrival, Susan presents her castaway narrative to an author named Mr. Foe. In a series of letters, Susan asks Foe, a celebrated storyteller, for money to support herself and Friday; she has given Foe permission to turn her story into a book, which she hopes will bring fame and riches to them all. In her letters, Susan struggles to cope with Friday's silence, reflecting on the importance of storytelling and communication. She addresses Mr. Foe's questions about the island; he is particularly curious about whether or not Friday ever engaged in cannibalism, though Susan assures him no such thing happened.

Susan stops hearing back from Mr. Foe, and she becomes increasingly anxious about how she will support herself and Friday. When she goes to Foe's house, she sees that two bailiffs have taken up residence, waiting to arrest Mr. Foe. Susan tries to learn about Foe's whereabouts from his maid Mrs. Thrush, but she is unsuccessful.

April becomes May, and still there is no word from Mr. Foe. Eventually, Susan and Friday move into Foe's abandoned home, which soothes Susan's spirits. In her letters, which are no longer

dated, Susan muses that her life in England is just as boring and unchanging as her life on the island was. With little else to think about, Susan begins to enjoy being able to order Friday around so easily—his silence makes him submissive.

A young girl has started silently watching Mr. Foe's house all day. At first, Susan assumes the girl is a messenger from either the bailiffs or Foe himself, but this proves not to be the case. To Susan's shock, the girl claims her name is also Susan Barton—she says she is Susan's long-lost daughter from Bahia. Susan is adamant that the girl is not her daughter, since she could never fail to recognize her daughter. Nevertheless, the young girl continues to insist that Susan is her mother, inventing a whole family backstory that has nothing in common with Susan's real life. Susan decides that Mr. Foe, wanting to add tension and resolution to her narrative, is responsible for this familial confusion, and she declares the girl "father-born."

Susan begins to despair, tiring of her silent companion and her endless routines. Fearing that Mr. Foe is dead, Susan wonders if she can write her story herself. But now she begins to understand why Mr. Foe was so desperate for some form of invented excitement in the tale: there is so little to write about. To enliven her narrative, Susan pays new attention to the island's "mysteries"—Cruso's obsession with the terraces and the backstory of how Friday lost his tongue. Susan also recalls a long-ago morning when Friday paddled out onto the ocean and scattered petals near where his ship had been wrecked.

Back in the house, Friday has started wearing Foe's robes and wigs and dancing wildly. In her letters to Foe, Susan starts to wonder if Friday really was a cannibal, and she even pictures him eating human flesh. One day, she finds a case of recorders, and she and Friday play music together—the same six-note song Friday played during Cruso's fever. But soon enough, Susan finds the song repetitive, and she tires even of that.

More time passes, and Susan and Friday embark on a journey to Bristol. The journey is difficult: two traveling soldiers almost assault Susan, and no innkeeper will take them in because of their bedraggled appearance. Along the way, Susan sees a dead baby, and she thinks that Friday might want to eat the baby—or even devour Susan alive. When the pair arrives in Bristol, Susan tries to put Friday on a ship back to Africa (though she has no clue where he is actually from). But she sees that all the captains who offer to take Friday will sell him back into slavery, and so, dejected, she and Friday return to London.

At long last, Susan and Friday reunite with Mr. Foe at his new London lodgings. Foe is working on the book, but he wants the focus to be on Susan's daughter and her time in Bahia. Susan refuses, even when Mr. Foe brings the young girl to his home, attempting once more to convince Susan that this is her daughter. Susan and Foe argue about who gets to pick and choose what goes in the book, and Susan realizes that "he has the last word who disposes over the greatest force." One night, Susan and Foe have sex, and it reminds Susan of her encounter

with Cruso.

Foe points out that the ship Cruso and Friday were on was almost certainly a slave ship—and that Cruso was likely a slaver. He says Friday was probably spreading petals on the water to honor the enslaved men and women lost to the shipwreck. Moreover, Foe sees Susan's unwillingness to understand Friday's perspective as "a slaver's stratagem," and he demands that she teach Friday how to write. Susan quickly grows frustrated, but Foe insists that Susan must teach Friday a new letter every day, and he gives Friday some of his own writing papers.

Suddenly, Susan's linear narrative breaks down, and the story begins to flash back and forth between Daniel Defoe's house and the underwater skeleton of Cruso's ship. An unnamed narrator—is it Susan?—swims into the shipwreck, where she sees Friday sitting. The unnamed narrator notices that there is a scar around Friday's neck. The narrator forces Friday's mouth open, and a slow stream comes from his lips. "Soft and cold, dark and unending," the narrator reflects, "it beats against my eyelids, against the skin of my face."



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Susan Barton – Susan Barton, an Englishwoman stranded on Cruso's **island**, is the narrator and protagonist of *Foe*. Upon being rescued and returning to London, Susan is desperate to profit off her narrative, and she outlines her island experiences in a series of letters to famed author Mr. Foe. But while Susan hopes to sell her story, she also wants to retain tremendous control over it, leaving out key details (mostly surrounding her relationship with her kidnapped daughter) and refusing to explore the internal life of Friday, her companion on the island and back in Europe. Over the course of the novel, Susan becomes more interested in the art of writing, and she tries to transform her monotonous days with Cruso into something more exciting and scandalous. In embracing the power of narrative, Susan (unwittingly) also begins to use this power in harmful ways: for example, by suggesting that Friday is a cannibal, she sews racist suspicions and obscures the horrors of slavery from the reader's view. Yet even as Susan uses her own narrative to elevate herself, ultimately, she is not a character at all in Mr. Foe's novel *Robinson Crusoe*—suggesting that just as she wrote Friday out of her story, Mr. Foe has done the same thing to her.

Friday – In both J. M. Coetzee's novel *Foe* and Daniel Defoe's novel *Robinson Crusoe*, Friday is Cruso's manservant and primary companion. In both stories, the two spend years together eking out a life on their remote **island**—but the similarities end there. In *Robinson Crusoe*, Friday is depicted as an indigenous man—Cruso saves him from a group of cannibals,

and the two become friends, with Friday telling Cruso about his past as a cannibal himself. *Foe* suggests a very different origin story for the two men. In Coetzee's version, Friday is a Black man, and Cruso is his enslaver—and even though they are the sole survivors of the wreck that destroys Cruso's slave ship, Cruso continues to view Friday as his servant. Most importantly, while Friday eventually learns some English in Defoe's version, the Friday of *Foe* has had his **tongue** violently cut out, rendering him unable to speak. Though Susan Barton never pays attention to Friday's inner life, preferring to be the sole storyteller of their time on the island, Friday does express himself in several ways throughout the text, whether painting, playing music, or drawing. Indeed, Mr. Foe believes that Friday—and the things his silence obscures—are the "heart of the story," even if Susan refuses to acknowledge it.

Mr. Foe – Mr. Foe based on the real author Daniel Defoe; historically, Foe lived and worked at the turn of the 18th century, making his living as a novelist, a journalist, and occasionally as a spy. Historically, Defoe was an intellectual leader, and due to his work on *Robinson Crusoe*, some consider him to be the father of the modern novel. But Defoe was also a controversial figure: the fictionalized Mr. Foe narrowly avoids arrest, but in real life, Defoe did spend some time in prison. Over the course of *Foe*, Mr. Foe forms a close and complicated bond with Susan Barton; he is interested in her story and attracted to her, but he is wary of her desire to leave out substantial chunks of her story. Foe is also critical of Susan's unwillingness to invest in Friday's perspective, seeing her refusal to share narrative power as a "slaver's stratagem." Ultimately, though, the book *Robinson Crusoe* reveals Mr. Foe to be guilty of nearly all the bad qualities he attributes to Susan: he, too, spreads racist rumors about Friday's cannibalism, and he writes Susan out of his narrative just as she writes all the inconvenient characters out of hers.

Cruso – Cruso is Robinson Crusoe, the famed adventurer at the heart of Daniel Defoe's 1719 novel of the same name. In both *Foe* and *Robinson Crusoe*, Cruso is an Englishman who gets stranded on a desert **island**, and in both stories, Cruso is an eager slave trader (who seems to feel no guilt about this practice). But whereas the Crusoe of Defoe's novel is resourceful, social, and deeply religious, the Cruso of *Foe* is gruff and silent, unwilling to engage meaningfully with either his servant Friday or Susan Barton. Even when Cruso does establish relationships, those relationships are largely transactional: he seems interested only in the tasks Friday can do, and though he and Susan have a brief sexual encounter, he shows no romantic interest in her. Only the **terraces** that Cruso builds on the island truly interest him, despite the fact that he has no crops to plant on them. Cruso's focus on these terraces demonstrate that he does care about his legacy and about being a productive member of whatever society he exists in.

Young girl – Though she claims to be Susan Barton’s daughter (and to share her name), it is never clear who this girl actually is—or even who she actually believes herself to be. What is clear, though, is that the young girl really does feel connected to Susan, though Susan insists that Mr. Foe is simply manipulating the girl to feel this way. In some ways, then, the young girl is a human manifestation of what happens when the lines between narrative and reality get blurred: even she herself does not understand which of her relationships is real and which is manufactured.

Amy – Amy is the servant girl that the young girl claims used to work for Susan Barton (in the girl’s version of events, Amy stayed on to raise her after her mother departed). It is unclear what aspects of Amy’s life are true or made up, though Susan assesses quickly that Amy is not very bright.

Mrs. Thrush – Mrs. Thrush is Mr. Foe’s maid at Stoke Newington, though she does not transition with him to his new Whitechapel house. When Susan comes to Stoke Newington in search of Foe, Mrs. Thrush is kind to her, though unable to help as she herself does not know where Foe has hidden.

Wilkes – Wilkes is the lead bailiff who takes up residence in Mr. Foe’s house, hoping to arrest Foe as soon as he returns; in the 1700s, this was common practice for bailiffs, who were the primary arresting officers of the law. The novel portrays Wilkes and his unnamed companion as slovenly and unpleasant.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Jack – Jack is a servant-boy in Mr. Foe’s second London house; Mr. Foe befriended him when Jack was living on the street and committing petty theft. Jack is clever and good-natured, and his relationship with Mr. Foe simultaneously demonstrates Mr. Foe’s generosity and his shrewd pragmatism.

Captain Smith – Captain Smith is the captain of the ship that rescues Susan, Cruso, and Friday. Though he is the person who suggests that Susan should take Cruso’s name and present herself as his wife, he also subtly propositions Susan for sex.

to Defoe by Susan Barton, an English widow stranded on Cruso’s **island** towards the end of his life. Upon her return to England, Susan insists that she is the only one who can tell the story of the castaways: Cruso has died, and Friday has had his **tongue** cut out and can no longer speak. But even though Susan is the sole narrator—both of the story and of *Foe* itself—it is clear that she is not telling a complete or unbiased tale. On the one hand, there are details Susan refuses to share, about her past in Brazil and her complex relationship with her daughter. And on the other hand, Susan begins to embellish new details, including an increasingly racist depiction of Friday. “I say he is a laundryman and he is a laundryman,” Susan boasts of Friday, “I say he is a cannibal and he is a cannibal.” In other words, because Susan is the person with the power to tell the story, she can also bend the facts of the story to her will.

But though Susan is the only speaking eyewitness to the events of the island, Defoe (or Mr. Foe, as Susan calls him) is the actual writer—and so poses a challenge to Susan’s control of the narrative. If Susan takes pleasure in blurring the lines between fiction and reality, she is not so pleased that Foe intervenes not only in her story but in her real life. And because Foe has material resources and societal privileges Susan does not, his version of the story eventually triumphs; just as Susan turned Friday into a cannibal in her narrative, Foe can erase Susan entirely from his. In the relationships between Foe, Susan, and Friday, existing power structures—especially around race and gender—replicate themselves in the shifting narrative of this island. And ultimately, *Foe* shows that control and storytelling exist in a vicious circle: people in power get to narrate the lives of those who are less powerful than them, and by perpetuating the narratives that benefit them, they also perpetuate their power.



ENSLAVEMENT, SILENCE, AND ERASURE

J. M. Coetzee’s *Foe* retells the story of Daniel Defoe’s 1719 novel [Robinson Crusoe](#) through the perspective of a white Englishwoman named Susan

Barton, who was stranded on a desert **island** with Cruso. As Susan narrates both her time on the island and her return to London, her stories are filled with mentions of Friday, a young Black man who was the only other survivor of Cruso’s shipwreck. Friday has mysteriously lost his **tongue**, and his silence is a source of both frustration and excitement for Susan; sometimes she is desperate for a conversation partner, while other times, Susan takes Friday’s lack of speech as an excuse to order him around or invent tales about his history. Even though Friday is present in nearly every moment of Susan’s story, the story never reveals anything about his life—only towards the end of the novel does Daniel Defoe (or Mr. Foe, as Susan calls him) point out that the ship Friday and Cruso were on was almost certainly a slave ship, that Cruso was probably a slave trader, and that hundreds of enslaved Black men and women



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don’t have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



STORYTELLING AND POWER

J. M. Coetzee’s *Foe* imagines an origin story for Daniel Defoe’s famous 1719 novel [Robinson Crusoe](#), about a white castaway named Crusoe and his Black manservant Friday. In Coetzee’s version, the story is told

were drowned in the wreckage.

Susan's omission of this crucial detail is telling: by erasing the obvious purpose of Cruso's voyage, Susan also erases both the brutal fact of slavery and her own subjection of Friday. Furthermore, though Susan is baffled by the fact that Cruso never taught Friday to write in all their years together, she too is hesitant to hear Friday's actual perspective; she pushes back when Mr. Foe gives Friday writing lessons, and demeans the music and drawings with which Friday expresses himself. Friday is silenced both literally (by the slaveholders who cut out his tongue) and metaphorically (by Susan, who denies him expression, and therefore interiority, in her narrative)—even Susan admits that Friday's lack of voice in her story is a way to keep him bound to her orders, just as "it was a slaver's stratagem to rob Friday of his tongue." Friday's silence in Susan's tale thus exemplifies the way that historically, white authors have obscured the violent truth of slavery, an erasure that allowed enslavement to persist for centuries beyond *Robinson Crusoe*'s publication.



EMBELLISHMENT VS. DECEPTION

When Susan Barton, the narrator of J. M. Coetzee's novel *Foe*, tries to tell the story of her time on Robinson Cruso's **island**, she struggles to make the story interesting: after all, so much of her time there was monotonous, spent braving the elements in silence with Cruso and his servant Friday. So in an effort to entice her audience, Susan begins to embellish, comparing herself to a painter "selecting and composing and rendering particulars in order to body forth a pleasing fullness in his scene." When Susan first begins refining her narrative, she experiments with harmless modifications: condensing events so that there is less dull time in between or including more scandalous details from her own private life. But as she gets increasingly desperate for attention (and the material wealth and fame that it will bring), Susan also gets increasingly dishonest in her storytelling. She invents romantic and sexual feelings for Cruso in direct contrast to the disinterest in him she had earlier expressed, and she starts editing out any details about her life before the island that could be seen as shameful. Most frighteningly, when Susan's collaborator Mr. Foe suggests that adding some cannibalism could make the story more attention-grabbing, Susan begins to paint Friday as a cannibal, a lie that immediately makes Friday a subject of speculation and distaste in their London neighborhood. In Susan's journey from boring honesty to salacious fantasy, *Foe* reveals the difference between embellishment and deception—and shows that while honest narration might be less interesting, invention can create prejudice and enact harm.



GENDER AND CREATION

In *Foe*, J. M. Coetzee reimagines Daniel Defoe's novel *Robinson Crusoe* from the perspective of Susan Barton, a castaway and the lone female witness to Cruso's time on an abandoned **island**. When Susan returns to England in the early 1700s, she is desperate to have Mr. Foe—a famous London writer of adventure stories—write and publish Cruso's tale. But Foe is initially less interested in Cruso than he is in Susan's life before the island, which she spent searching for her kidnapped daughter in Bahia, Brazil. Susan is hesitant to share any details about her relationship with her daughter, but Foe is determined, even trying to convince Susan that a young girl she has never met before is her daughter—because he believes the story will be more satisfying if it ends with a reunion between mother and daughter.

As Susan and Foe fight for creative control over Susan's story (and over the facts of Susan's family life), the gender norms of the era are confused and complicated. On the one hand, Susan insists that the young girl is not her daughter but is instead "father-born" by Mr. Foe, because she is a product of his scheming and imagination. On the other hand, Susan insists that she is the "father" of her story, while Mr. Foe is the mother; she "begets" it, but it is Mr. Foe's job to write it and (metaphorically) carry it to term. And while Susan remains financially and materially dependent on Mr. Foe, when the two begin a romantic relationship, Susan experiments with sexual dominance, explicitly equating her power in the bedroom with her power as a storyteller. In claiming creative control, Susan is therefore able to subvert the strict, misogynistic gender roles of her era, suggesting that artistic invention is a venue for women to seize agency denied to them in other realms of life.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



ISLANDS

The desert island is the literal setting for much of J. M. Coetzee's novel *Foe*, but the idea of islands also symbolizes the difficulty of communication. Despite being more social on the island than she is at any other time in the story, protagonist Susan Barton almost never uses language there, as one of her companions (Friday) has lost his **tongue**, while the other (Cruso) sees little need for words (either spoken or written). But when Susan returns to England, living with Friday in Mr. Foe's house, communicating with others does not get any easier. Instead, she marvels that her life in London is just as silent and isolated as her time on the island, and she imagines that Mr. Foe, in hiding and alone, must be feeling similarly. "The

world is full of islands,” Susan reflects; over the course of the novel, she comes to realize that those who are arrested, shunned, or even just separated from their loved ones can feel like “castaways in the very heart of the city.” Thus, islands come to represent the way that humans can be lonely even in—or sometimes especially in—a dense city or a closely packed home.



FRIDAY'S TONGUE

Friday, one of the main characters in J. M. Coetzee's novel *Foe*, has lost his tongue under mysterious circumstances. In a story so concerned with storytelling and power, Friday's tongue—or its absence—represents how white-authored fiction and history erases the horror of enslavement. Moreover, because Friday cannot speak for himself—and because Susan Barton, the story's narrator and protagonist, never tries to teach Friday how to write—Friday never gets to express either his perspective or his interiority. Instead, by taking advantage of Friday's silence, Susan gains control of Friday's internal life as well as his external life: “I say he is a laundryman and he is a laundryman,” Susan crows, “I say he is a cannibal and he is a cannibal.” Importantly, though little is known about the circumstances under which Friday has lost his tongue, Coetzee's novel repeatedly emphasizes the violence that must have accompanied the removal of such a tender body part. In addition to symbolizing the erasure of Black voices and experiences from the archive, then, Friday's tongue also makes clear that this kind of erasure is inherently a violent act.



TERRACES

Cruso's terraces, intended to make the desert island something more like an English garden, represent the connection between labor, legacy, and community. For Susan Barton, island life comes with only two goals: to escape, and to create some written record of her time there. By contrast, her companion Cruso and Friday, the man he's enslaved, spend all their time leveling ground and moving stone to make their terraces—even though they have no crops to plant on the terraces (as Cruso explains, “the planting is reserved for those who come after us [...] I only clear the ground for them”). And tellingly, while Cruso devotes hours to these terraces, he has not created a single writing implement for himself—nor, to Susan's frustration, does he have any interest in writing down the details of his time on the island. Susan believes that narrative is the only way to be remembered, but Cruso's focus on the terraces suggests that he is interested in leaving a different kind of legacy. Whereas Susan wants to get a good story out of the island and then abandon it, Cruso only wants to be remembered as a part of his island. Ultimately, then, Cruso's labor on the terraces

symbolizes a form of legacy building that is generous instead of extractive: “not every man who bears the mark of a castaway,” Cruso explains, “is a castaway at heart.” At the same time, though, because the terraces remain unused, they also suggest the impossibility of giving back in isolation; without the seeds that other people might bring, Cruso's terraces can never be truly productive or meaningful.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Penguin edition of *Foe* published in 1988.

Part 1 Quotes

☞ One day [Cruso] would say his father had been a wealthy merchant whose counting-house he had quit in search of adventure. But the next day he would tell me he had been a poor lad of no family who had shipped as a cabin boy and been captured by the Moors (he bore a scar on his arm which was, he said, the mark of the branding iron) and escaped and made his way to the new world. Sometimes he would say he had dwelt on his island in the past 15 years, he and Friday, none but they having been spared when their ship went down. [...] Yet at other times, as for instance when he was in the grip of the fever...he would tell stories of cannibals, of how Friday was a cannibal whom he had saved from being roasted and devoured by fellow cannibals...So in the end I did not know what was truth, what was lies, and what was mere rambling.

Related Characters: Susan Barton, Cruso (speaker), Friday

Related Themes:

Related Symbols:

Page Number: 8

Explanation and Analysis

As Susan tries to retell Cruso's life story, she struggles to piece together the various—and conflicting—narratives he has given her. Importantly, Cruso has been on the island for years; one of his only forms of entertainment in all that time has been his own memory, which he can embellish or erase as he sees fit. The division Susan makes between “truth,” “lies,” and “mere rambling” is therefore a false dichotomy: after so long without any other speaker to verify or contradict his stories, fact and fiction have probably gotten muddled for Cruso as much as for Susan, his listener. And indeed, as her narrative goes on and she grows more and more desperate for excitement, Susan herself will struggle

to differentiate between her own truths and her own lies.

The other thing to note here is the already-diverging truth of Friday's life. In one version of Cruso's story, Friday has suffered unbearable traumas, experiencing slavery and a shipwreck all while he was a small child. In the other version, Friday is a cannibal, both in danger and the *source* of danger. As both Susan and Cruso narrate their stories, they will toggle between these two depictions of Friday, making him victim or victimizer depending on what is most convenient for each part of the narrative.

☞ Seen from too remote a vantage, life begins to lose its particularity. All shipwrecks become the same shipwreck, all castaways the same castaway, sunburnt, lonely, clad in the skins of the beast he has slain. The truth that makes your story yours alone, that sets you apart from the old mariner by the fireside spinning yarns of sea monsters and mermaids, resides in a thousand touches which today may seem of no importance, such as: when you made your needle...by what means did you pierce the eye? When you sewed your hat, what did you use for thread? Touches like these will one day persuade your countrymen that it is all true, every word, there was an indeed once an island in the middle of the ocean where the wind blew and the gulls cried from the cliffs.

Related Characters: Susan Barton (speaker), Cruso

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 13

Explanation and Analysis

Despite Susan's pleadings, Cruso has no interest in fashioning writing implements for his remote island, much less actually writing down the details of his life there. Susan fears, rightfully, that without being able to record events as they happen in the moment, the days will blend into each other. And perhaps even more frighteningly, without detail, there is no separation between people, either—Cruso could be any castaway, as his story is no longer set "apart."

Though Susan will later come to believe that what makes a story exciting is conflict, sexual scandal, and violence, in this brief moment of insight, she has a more nuanced view of "particularity." Whether on an island or in the crush of a dense city, life will always begin to feel monotonous and routine. What gives it meaning, Susan suggests, is the

everyday occurrences which "may seem of no importance." Rather than inventing or being dishonest, in this moment, *Foe* poses a more truthful way of finding excitement in life: by paying attention to the "thousand touches" of experience.

☞ "Where is the justice in it? First a slave and now a castaway too. Robbed of his childhood and consigned to a life of silence. Was Providence sleeping?"

"If Providence were to watch over all of us," said Cruso, "who would be left to pick the cotton and cut the sugar cane? For the business of the world to prosper, Providence must sometimes wake and sometimes sleep, as lower creatures do."

Related Characters: Susan Barton, Cruso (speaker), Friday

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 19

Explanation and Analysis

When Susan learns the outline of Friday's life story, she is horrified to discover how many awful things have happened to the relatively young man. But while Susan feels that such a slew of traumas flies in the face of faith and Christian principle, Cruso argues that it would be impossible for god ("Providence") to "watch over all of us" equally. Instead, Cruso suggests that for "the business of the world" to continue, some people must be unlucky, forced into picking cotton and cutting cane so that other people can wear fine clothes and eat sweet cakes.

Cruso's logic amounts to a justification of racialized slavery: he is effectively saying that a higher power is "[a]sleep" to the needs of enslaved Black men and women. This belief system is especially salient given what Mr. Foe will make clear towards the end—that Cruso was likely a slave trader, not just coexisting with chattel slavery but actively participating in and profiting from it.

But it's also important to pay attention, as always, to the fact that Susan Barton is telling this story. As she herself admits, there was nothing to write on the island, so this conversation is recreated from memory, many months after the fact; she therefore is able to rearrange or redistribute dialogue as she sees fit. And this exchange reflects just how tricky Susan can be—she at once distances herself from the logic of slavery and gives it credence, having Cruso

articulate it without any challenge. Susan's ability to present herself as removed from slavery even as she benefits it will become one of the central threads of the novel.

“The planting is not for us,” said [Cruso]. “We have nothing to plant—that is our misfortune...the planting is reserved for those who come after us and have the foresight to bring seed. I only clear the ground for them. Clearing ground and piling stones is little enough, but it is better than sitting in idleness...I ask you to remember, not every man who bears the mark of the castaway is a castaway at heart.”

Related Characters: Cruso (speaker), Susan Barton

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 28

Explanation and Analysis

Though it frustrates Susan to no end that Cruso refuses to make writing implements, she can hardly accuse him of laziness: he and Friday spend all day carrying stones and leveling ground, building terraces into the harsh terrain of the island. Susan believes narrative is the most surefire way to preserve one's legacy, but Cruso disagrees, instead wanting to be remembered via his tangible impact on the land of the island itself. This reflects a mindset common among British settlers of this time, who felt that “improvements”—fences, plow marks, and the like—guaranteed a man's permanent ownership over a piece of land.

Moreover, while Susan wants to extract fame from the island (by escaping and telling her story), Cruso is more interested in ways that he can give back to the island. He sees himself as clearing the grounding for future generations; when he and Friday labor for hours on end, they do so cognizant of the fact that they will never see the reward. Cruso's optimistic approach to legacy thus stands in stark contrast to Susan's individualistic understanding of the island's uses. And in taking this more communal view of his labor, Cruso also becomes a “castaway” in body only, not in his “heart”; by building these terraces, he is able to imagine himself as part of a larger society, just one that has yet to arrive.

“I used once to think, when I saw Cruso in this evening posture, that, like me, he was searching the horizon for a sail. But I was mistaken. His visit to the bluff belonged to a practice of losing himself in the contemplation of the waste of water and sky. Friday never interrupted him during these retreats; when one site innocently approached him, I was rebuffed with angry words, and for days afterwards he and I did not speak. To me, sea and sky remained sea and sky, vacant and tedious. I had not the temperament to love such emptiness.”

Related Characters: Susan Barton (speaker), Friday, Cruso

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 33

Explanation and Analysis

Susan, Cruso, and Friday all spend time exploring the island by themselves, but while Susan is always focused on getting away from it, Cruso's walks are much more contemplative. The fact that Cruso gets “angry” when Susan interrupts suggests that these lonely moments are important to him; clearly, he finds real meaning and beauty in the vast, repetitive, “emptiness” of the sea and the sky. Once again, then, this passage reflects the divergence between Susan's extractive view of the island and Cruso's more patient, searching approach.

Susan's disdain and discomfort with such “emptiness” is particularly important. Rather than seeking to find excitement in monotony, in the crest of a wave or the shape of a cloud, she writes it all off as a “waste,” “vacant and tedious.” This refusal to engage with empty space will define Susan's central struggle when she turns to storytelling: instead of trying to find meaning in the quiet, repetitive island as it actually was, Susan begins to invent exciting events that never occurred, preferring external conflict to internal feeling.

“Did they truly think of me as Cruso's wife, or had tales already reached them—sailors' haunts are full of gossip—of the Englishwoman from Bahia marooned in the Atlantic by Portuguese mutineers? Do you think of me, Mr. Foe, as Mrs. Cruso, or as a bold adventuress? Think what you may, it was I who shared Cruso's bed and closed Cruso's eyes, as it is I who have disposal of all that Cruso leaves behind, which is the story of his island.”

Related Characters: Susan Barton (speaker), Cruso

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 40

Explanation and Analysis

At the end of her island narrative, Susan at last makes manifest who she has been writing to—Mr. Foe, her name for the real-life author of travelogues, Daniel Defoe. In concluding her story this way, Susan reveals several key traits. First, she is tremendously concerned with the impression she makes—she wants to know whether she will be seen as a wife or an “adventuress,” but more than that, she is desperate to ensure that she is known as *something*.

In addition to seeing Susan’s concern for her own fame, she also seems—for the first time—to acknowledge the power she has as an eyewitness storyteller. She boasts of “hav[ing] disposal” over the entire story of the island; since Friday cannot speak, Cruso is dead, and there was nobody else on the island, no one can contradict what she might say. (The fact that Susan claims all Cruso “leaves behind” also transforms her into his widow, of sorts—and though no character named Susan Barton appears in Daniel Defoe’s *Robinson Crusoe*, the “widow” is a prominent figure.)

And finally, Susan conflates her sexual contact with Cruso to her storytelling control: “it was I who shared Cruso’s bed and closed Cruso’s eyes,” she says, linking her intimacy with him to being able to represent life through “Cruso’s eyes.” Sex and storytelling will become more closely entangled as the novel goes on, but even from this first interaction with Mr. Foe, Susan seems to realize that sex and writing are two ways in which she can transcend gender roles, claiming a “bold[ness]” that is otherwise denied to her as a woman.

Related Characters: Susan Barton (speaker), Mr. Foe, Cruso

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 45

Explanation and Analysis

As Susan languishes in London, unable to do anything but reflect and wait for Mr. Foe to write his story, she begins to doubt her own reality. Since Susan feels she has given Cruso “substance” by writing his story, she is now desperate for Mr. Foe to tell the world that she “ate and drank,” “woke and slept”—and thus to remind her of her own humanity. Susan’s strange logic dictates that a person can only be real once they are fictionalized, written down in a popular book and distributed to the masses. In other words, Susan believes that the “substance” of reality can only come through artistic imagination.

This crucial passage thus marks the first time that Susan suggests there is a difference between the facts and “the truth.” The facts are what an eyewitness can deliver, but the truth must come from remove: from “a comfortable chair,” and the ability to “see” what is not actually there. If this is so, then the “truth” at the center of any good story—at least in Susan’s mind—demands embellishment and creation.

Lastly, Susan’s use of word “capture” once more demonstrates that there is something almost violently powerful about telling someone else’s story; the word “capture” also implicitly links the practice of storytelling to the practice of enslavement.

Part 2 Quotes

☞ When I reflect on my story I seem to exist only as the one who came, the one who witnessed, the one who longed to be gone: of being without substance, a ghost beside the true body of Cruso. Is that the fate of all storytellers? Yet I was as much a body as Cruso. I ate and drank, I woke and slept...Return to me the substance I have lost, Mr. Foe: that is my entreaty for though my story gives the truth, it does not give the substance of the truth (I see that clearly, we need not pretend it is otherwise). To tell the truth in all its substance you must have quiet, and a comfortable chair away from all distraction, and a window to stare through; and then the knack of seeing waves when there are fields before your eyes, and of feeling the tropic sun when it is cold; and at your fingertips the words with which to capture the vision before it fades. I have none of these, while you have all.

☞ Day by day the wind picks at the roof and the weeds creep across the terraces. In a year, in ten years, there will be nothing left standing but a circle of sticks to mark the place where the hut stood, and of the terraces only the walls. And of the walls they will say, These are cannibal walls, the ruins of a cannibal city, from the golden age of the cannibals. For who will believe they were built by one man and a slave, in the hope that one day a seafarer would come with a sack of corn for them to sow?

Related Characters: Susan Barton (speaker), Cruso

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 48

Explanation and Analysis

Susan cannot shake the memory of endless wind beating down on Cruso's now abandoned terraces. It is worth seeing that, while Susan dreads the repetitive wind, even she has to admit that monotony can create change; "day by day" the wind feels the same, but "in ten years" it will have eradicated giant structures. There is meaning (and even drama) in monotony, though Susan does not often recognize that fact.

This passage also shows how difficult it is to control the narrative around one's actions. Cruso hoped to be seen as a skilled, generous laborer, but in a decade, his handiwork may be erased entirely or attributed only to "cannibals" (a term that, throughout the novel, is often used as a racist descriptor of Black men). If manual labor does not leave a permanent legacy, then perhaps Susan is correct in assuming that narrative is the only way to have lasting, permanent control over how she is perceived.

consciousness about this reality ("do you think less of me for this confession?", she asks Cruso) is also telling.

Coetzee is also subtly threading this passage with the language that white people often used to justify slavery. "Benevolence" was a word that self-titled "progressive" slaveholders used to claim superiority over their other, even more brutal, counterparts; "educat[ion]" was a primary excuse for slavery, and the image of enslaved people as "dark" and "silen[t]" was frequently used to justify racist hierarchies. So even when Susan thinks she is examining her prejudices openly, she does not realize how thoroughly her worldview—and the language she uses to describe it—has been corrupted by the logic of slavery.

☞ I tell myself I talked to Friday to educate him out of darkness and silence. But is that the truth? There are times when benevolence deserts me and I use words only as the shortest way to subject him to my will. At such times I understand why Cruso preferred not to disturb his muteness. I understand, that is to say, why a man will choose to be a slave owner. Do you think less of me for this confession?

Related Characters: Susan Barton (speaker), Friday, Mr. Foe, Cruso

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 54

Explanation and Analysis

Now that Cruso is dead and Susan and Friday spend all their time together, Susan is finding new ways—and new words—to put Friday to work. In this unusually reflective moment, she admits that language can be a tool for communication or for erasure; instead of learning about Friday's interior life, she uses words to enforce her "will" on his own. The fact that Susan feels not guilt but self-

☞ It is not wholly as I imagined it would be. What I thought would be your writing-table is not a table but a bureau. The window overlooks not woods and pastures but your garden. There is no ripple in the glass. The chest is not a true chest but a dispatch box. Nevertheless, it is all close enough. Does it surprise you as much as it does me, this correspondence between things as they are and the pictures we have of them in our minds?

Related Characters: Susan Barton (speaker), Friday, Mr. Foe, Cruso

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 58

Explanation and Analysis

After weeks of being adjacent to or in close proximity with Mr. Foe, Susan at last gains access to his writing room. With little else to do, Susan has spent days trying to envision this desk—and though the view out the window is different and some of the furniture is differently shaped, "it is all close enough" to what she "imagined" to be satisfying.

In pointing out these "correspondences," Susan does two things. First, she allies herself with Mr. Foe, giving credence to the mental "pictures" writers create and then put on paper. But she is also teaching her readers to have faith in invention—after all, she pictured this writing room, and the reality ended up being "close enough." By building her readers' trust in her own imagination, Susan can then get increasingly far from the facts, leading her readers down the (often dangerous) path of embellishment.

☛☛ Dubiously I thought: are these enough strange circumstances to make a story of? How long before I am driven to invent new and stranger circumstances: the salvage of tools and muskets from Cruso's ship; the building of a boat, or at least a skiff, an adventure to sail to the mainland; a landing by cannibals on the island, followed by a skirmish and many bloody deaths; and, at last, becoming of a golden haired stranger with a sack of corn, and the planting of the terraces? Alas, will the day ever arrive when we can make a story without strange circumstances?

Related Characters: Susan Barton (speaker), Cruso

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols:  

Page Number: 60

Explanation and Analysis

Susan has stopped hearing from Mr. Foe, and she begins to worry that her story is not interesting enough to merit his continued attention (not to mention his financial support). Interestingly, many of the made-up circumstances Susan lists here do find their way into Daniel Defoe's real-life novel *Robinson Crusoe*; in that book, cannibals arrive on the island, Cruso builds a boat, and there is both a skirmish and an escape. Ultimately, then, those who have read Defoe's novel understand that the "new and stranger circumstances" Susan is tempted to make up win the day.

There are two other important details in this passage. First, even in Defoe's book, the terraces never get planted—suggesting that no one but Cruso really values the island as a focal point, a place worth maintaining in and of itself instead of merely writing about it. And second, it is telling that Susan uses the phrase "driven to" to describe her eventual invention. By putting her embellishment in the passive voice, Susan makes it feel inevitable and avoids responsibility for the lies she will later spread. Here, as elsewhere, Susan manipulates language to skirt the blame for her dishonesty (and her slander of Friday).

☛☛ You will believe me when I say the life we lead grows less and less distinct from the life we lead on Cruso's island. Sometimes I wake up not knowing where I am. The world is full of islands, said Cruso once. His words ring truer every day.

Related Characters: Susan Barton (speaker), Mr. Foe, Cruso

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 65

Explanation and Analysis

While she was on the island, Susan's singular goal was to get back to England, where she could socialize and mix up her days. But now that she is in London, she is faced with the same monotony—confined in a small space with Friday as her primary companion and living almost wordlessly and only for subsistence. Even the repeated word "lead" emphasizes how similar the island routine is to the routine that Susan and Friday now share.

Though Susan does not say it herself, it is a fair question to wonder if this monotony is completely out of her control. That's especially true given that she could choose another life for herself, now that she is back in London: she could easily get a job as a maid or servant, but she refuses to do so, citing a litany of excuses. Instead, Susan is determined to profit off what she feels are the unique and exciting aspects of her life—even as she bemoans that same life's uneventfulness.

Most important, though, is Cruso's insight that "the world is full of islands." If a desert island is literally cut off from the rest of the world by water, Susan now feels that same sense of remove from society and companionship. Indeed, the novel is filled with examples of other urban "islands"—whether it is Foe hiding out by himself or Susan's fearfulness of London's prison, nicknamed the "Fleet" in part because it casts men out into emotional waters. In other words, as Susan is quickly learning, isolation is not only a question of geography; instead, isolation can only be fixed by reciprocal communication and day-to-day excitement.

“Oh, Friday, how can I make you understand the cravings felt by those of us who live in a world of speech to have our questions answered! It is like our desire, when we kiss someone, to feel the lips we kiss respond to us. Otherwise would we not be content to bestow our kisses on statues, the cold statues of kings and queens and gods and goddesses? Why do you think we do not kiss statues, and sleep with statues in our beds, men with the statues of women and women with the statues of men, statues carved in positions of desire? Do you think it is only because marble is cold? Lie long enough with a statue in your bed, with warm covers over the two of you, and the marble will grow warm. No, it is not because the statue is cold but because it is dead, or rather because it has never lived and never will.”

Related Characters: Susan Barton (speaker), Friday

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 72

Explanation and Analysis

Weeks have turned into months, and Mr. Foe is still not responding to any of Susan's letters; to make matters worse, Friday is now in one of what Crusoe labeled his “mopes,” in which he falls into a depression and distances himself from everyone around him. Susan does not make any effort to understand what Friday is suffering (though later it will become clear that he is probably in a period of intense grief, perhaps because of the hundreds of enslaved Black men and women who died in the shipwreck). Instead, Susan paints Friday's silence and distance as evidence that he has “never lived,” further justifying her ignorance of his internal life in favor of discussing her own “cravings.”

The other thing to note here is Susan's continued conflation of sexual, physical communication with the “world of speech.” Though Susan claims to wish that Friday would respond with his words, this passage is almost sexual: she cries out “oh” and uses exclamation points, lost in a reverie as she pictures “feel[ing] the lips” of a lover. Even the choice of words like “craving” and “desire” amplify that Susan's desire for language is sexual in nature—or that what she desires from Friday is not language at all, but perhaps bodily intimacy.

“I must go, Friday. You thought that carrying stones was the hardest of labours. But when you see me at Mr. Foe's desk making marks with the quill, think of each mark as a stone, and think of the paper as the island, and imagine that I must disperse the stones over the face of the island, and when that is done and the taskmaster is not satisfied (was Crusoe ever satisfied with your labours?) must pick them up again (which, in the figure, is scoring out the marks and disposed them according to another scheme), and so forth, day after day; all of this because Mr. Foe has run away from his debts. Sometimes I believe it is I who have become the slave. No doubt you would smile, if you could understand.”

Related Characters: Susan Barton (speaker), Friday, Mr. Foe, Crusoe

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 80

Explanation and Analysis

Since Mr. Foe has still not responded to any of Susan's letters, Susan decides to take matters into her own hands and write the story herself. Here, she explicitly equates the kind of legacy-building labor Crusoe was doing (moving stones around on the island to create terraces) with the writing she is taking on. Susan notes that both labors involve editing and rearranging the reality of what is there—whether it is stones or memories—and that both are frustratingly repetitive (“and so forth,” Susan resigns herself, “day after day”).

As she compares her labor to Friday's work on the terraces, Susan elides a crucial difference: she has chosen this labor for herself, while Friday was forced into it. But Susan nevertheless finds a way to depict herself as enslaved—and more than that, to say she is “the slave,” suggesting that she is in bondage while Friday is not. Susan is therefore effectively rewriting the power dynamic between herself and Friday to make her the victim and him the victimizer. Worst of all, because Friday does not have the language to comprehend what Susan is saying, she can imagine his agreement to this twisted role reversal—“you would smile,” she tells him, though she has no evidence of any such thing.

●● A painter engaged to paint a dull scene—let us say two men digging in a field—has means at hand to lend alert to his subject. He can set the golden hues of the first man's skin against the sturdy hues of the seconds, creating a play of light against dark. By artfully representing their attitudes he can indicate which is master, which slave. And to render his composition more lively he is at liberty to bring into it what may not be there on the day he paints but may be there on other days, such as a pair of gulls wheeling overhead, the beak of one parted in a cry, and in one corner, upon a faraway crag, a band of apes. Thus we see the painter selecting and composing and rendering particulars in order to body forth a pleasing fullness in his scene. The storyteller, by contrast (forgive me, I would not lecture you on storytelling if you were here in the flesh!), must divine which episodes of his history hold promise of fullness, and tease from them they're hidden meanings, writing these together as one braids a rope.

Related Characters: Susan Barton (speaker), Mr. Foe

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 81

Explanation and Analysis

After several tries at putting her narrative on paper, Susan starts to get the hang of things, comparing herself to a painter hard at work. As she digs deep into this painting metaphor, Susan begins to blur the lines between art and artifice. The painter may condense time so that his work feels “more lively,” or he may “select” some details and then “leave out” the ones that are less “pleasing” to him. But while the painting makes no claim to tell a true story, Susan's entire hope is to make money from capturing her own reality—from writing down what really happened. This metaphor, which gives her permission to edit and embellish, is therefore both convenient and faulty.

There are two other critical details in this passage. First, Susan not-so-subtly equates power with skin color. Though she does not explicitly write that slavery is a question of “light against dark,” she makes clear that in this metaphorical painting—as in her book—there is one white man and one Black one, and that the first is the master of the second. Susan also suggests that the artist has the power to reinforce this hierarchical relationship, once more showing how narrative can not only depict but sometimes determine reality.

And second, Susan now embraces the concept of “hidden meanings,” as she concludes that eyewitness testimony misses the real truths, which must be “tease[d]” out instead of merely recounted. There is certainly some truth to this;

great storytellers are great because they linger on private thoughts and feelings. But Susan will use this “hidden” content as an excuse for invention, adding false stories—especially of Friday's cannibalism—to give her story the “fullness” she so badly wants.

●● “You are father-born. You have no mother. The pain you feel is the pain of lack, not the pain of loss. What you hope to regain in my person you have in truth never had.”
“Father-born,” [the girl] says—“It is a word I have never heard before.”

Related Characters: Susan Barton, Young girl (speaker), Mr. Foe

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 84

Explanation and Analysis

Susan, having been repeatedly approached by a young girl who claims to be her daughter, decides that the girl's presence must be Mr. Foe's doing—his manipulative way of reintroducing her to her lost child and, in doing so, ensuring his story's happy ending. It follows, then, that Susan's false child is made not in a mother's womb but in a father's imagination, hence the term “father-born.” The girl's marvel at this new term also shows how much language can invent reality. Even if “father-born” is a word she has “never heard before,” as soon as Susan coins it, a new kind of lineage becomes possible.

If Foe indeed sent this girl to Susan, it is proof of the two writers' similarity. Just as Susan has conflated sex with the storytelling process, she now sees Foe's plot-creation as a kind of childbirth. Conversely, Foe begins to bring forth people as easily as he might bring forth a page of text, becoming a “father” both creatively and in flesh and blood. And this inversion seemingly bodes well for Susan as a female writer, something nearly unheard of in the early modern era—after all, if a man can give birth to a person, a woman can certainly create a story.

☛ I forgot you are a writer who knows above all how many words can be sucked from a cannibal feast, how few from a woman cowering from the wind. It is all a matter of words and the number of words, is it not? Friday sits at his table in his wig and robes and eats pease pudding. I ask myself: did human flesh once pass those lips - truly, cannibals are terrible; but most terrible of all is to think of the little cannibal children, their eyes closing in pleasure as they chew the tasty fat of their neighbors. I shiver. For surely eating human flesh is like falling into sin: having fallen once you discover in yourself a taste for it, you fall all the more readily thereafter. I shiver as I watch Friday dancing in the kitchen.

Related Characters: Susan Barton (speaker), Friday, Mr. Foe

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 87

Explanation and Analysis

More time has passed, and Susan still has yet to receive a response from Mr. Foe. Before she desperately tries to put Friday on a ship out of England, she writes one more letter, offering new sympathy for Mr. Foe's earlier fascination with cannibalism. After struggling to fill pages with the repetitive story of her own "cowering from the wind," she now understands that scandalizing tales of "sin" and carnage can give her more words to write—and more words will equal more readers, more profit.

Importantly, Susan then seeks to "suck" further profit from Friday's life (though the choice of the word "suck" suggests it is Susan, not Friday, who is actually the cannibal). Even as Friday sits and eats his porridge, which Susan has earlier mentioned is his favorite food, she twists the peaceful scene to become a more violent one. Indeed, every act that brings Friday joy—eating, dancing, wearing Mr. Foe's robes—now becomes an excuse for Susan to paint him as a monstrosity, enriching her story and (she hopes) eventually herself.

As Mr. Foe will later point out, this is the ultimate "slaver's stratagem"; to benefit herself, Susan will exploit Friday for profit and demonize him, painting herself as the "shiver[ing]" victim. And by shifting the monstrosity onto Friday, Susan obscures the horror of her own actions from her readers.

Part 3 Quotes

☛ You err most tellingly in failing to distinguish between my silences and the silences of a being such as Friday. Friday has no command of words and therefore no defense against being re-shaped day by day in conformity with the desires of others. I say he is a cannibal and he becomes a cannibal; I say he is a laundryman and he becomes a laundryman. What is the truth of Friday? You will respond: he is neither cannibal nor laundryman, these are mere names, they do not touch his essence, he is a substantial body, he is himself, Friday is Friday. But that is not so. No matter what he is to himself (is he anything to himself? - how can he tell us?), what he is to the world is what I make of him...Whereas the silence I keep regarding Bahia and other matters is chosen and purposeful: it is my own silence.

Related Characters: Susan Barton (speaker), Friday, Mr. Foe

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 113

Explanation and Analysis

After his months-long absence, Foe has returned to England and reunited with Susan and Friday. But though Susan has hoped for this reunion as the answer to all her problems, she is disappointed to realize that Foe is more interested in the story of her daughter than the story of the island. In this monologue, Susan asserts that she will not talk about her daughter, and she argues that because her "silences" are purposeful, they must be honored. She also explains her logic: because she has "command of words," she also has a concrete "essence" that no one (not Friday, not Crusoe, not Foe) can disturb.

But to make her own point clear, Susan denies "substan[ce]"—and even humanity—to Friday, whom she describes as a "being" instead of a human or person. Perhaps nowhere else in the novel is the relationship between language and slavery so clearly articulated. Because Susan has control ("command") over the narrative, she can force Friday into whatever she wants him to be: "I say he is a cannibal and he becomes a cannibal." And because Friday does not have a tongue, he cannot ever contest Susan's falsities—so "he is to the world what I make of him," she crows. By claiming control of language, Susan denies Friday any sort of interiority and then claims that his lack of interiority is the justification for forcing Friday into servitude. This circular logic is one of the novel's clearest

allegories for the logic of slavery as a whole, as white slaveholders bolstered their power by erasing and dehumanizing the Black folks they enslaved.

☞ To me the moral is that he has the last word who disposes over the greatest force. I mean the executioner and his assistants, both great and small. If I were the Irish woman, I should rest most uneasy in my grave knowing to what interpreter the story of my last hours has been consigned.

Related Characters: Susan Barton (speaker), Mr. Foe

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 116

Explanation and Analysis

Despite Mr. Foe's various forms of pressure, Susan still refuses to tell him the story of her daughter and Bahia. So in a final attempt to convince her, Foe tells the story of an Irishwoman who delays her execution with fanciful, false confessions—until finally the chaplain on duty walks away, leaving her to be killed. As Susan analyzes this story, she comes to the conclusion that (implicitly violent) “force” determines who gets to tell stories, or who gets “the last word.” Susan is realizing that history is written by the victors, which means that storytelling is both an act of power and a result of it.

The other thing to note here is Susan's hesitance at being described in a way she is uncomfortable with; she understands that the wrong “interpreter” can do real harm, both in life and to a person's legacy. Yet hypocritically, she has no such hesitance about “teas[ing]” out the “hidden meanings” of Friday's life, showing once more that Susan is neither a reliable narrator nor a sympathetic one.

☞ I am not a story, Mr. Foe. I may impress you as a story because I began my account of myself without preamble, slipping overboard into the water and striking out for the shore. But my life did not begin in the waves. There was a life before the water which stretched back to my desolate searchings in Brazil, thence to the years when my daughter was still with me, and so on back to the day I was born. All of which makes up a story I do not choose to tell. I choose not to tell it because to no one, not even to you, do I owe proof that I am a substantial being with a substantial history in the world. I choose rather to tell of the island, of myself and Cruso and Friday and what we three did there: for I am a free woman who asserts her freedom by telling her story according to her own desire.

Related Characters: Susan Barton (speaker), Friday, Mr. Foe, Cruso, Young girl

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 122

Explanation and Analysis

Frustrated by the continued back-and-forth about her time in Bahia, Susan finally snaps at Mr. Foe. Susan's frustration is fascinating, largely because it is so different from how she felt at the beginning of *Foe*; whereas once she fretted that only Mr. Foe could “return to me the substance I have lost,” now she feels that she does not “owe proof” to anyone of her reality. Perhaps this newfound confidence comes from Susan's faith that she can control the narrative; she can begin in the middle (“slipping overboard into the water”), and she can “choose not to tell” the more private, more embarrassing episodes in her life.

A couple of other details merit attention here. The fact that Susan is so staunchly opposed to sharing the story of her daughter suggests that there is something more complicated than the straightforward tale of kidnapping she has hinted at; is Susan culpable in her daughter's absence? Also, Susan again conflates female agency with literary creation, and literary creation with sex: she boasts that she is a “free woman” who gains that freedom via “telling her story,” and she uses the word “desire” to defend her narrative impulses. Sex and storytelling are perhaps the only avenues where, as an English woman in the early 18th century, Susan can gain true “freedom.”

“I calmed Foe. ‘Permit me,’ I whispered—‘there is a privilege that comes with the first night, that I claim as mine.’ So I coaxed him till he lay beneath me. Then I drew off my shift and straddled him (which he did not seem easy with, in a woman). This is the manner of the Muse when she visits her poets, I whispered, and felt some of the listlessness go out of my limbs.

“A bracing ride,” said Foe afterwards—“My very bones are jolted, I must catch my breath before I resume.” “It is always a hard ride when the Muse pays her visits,” I replied—“she must do whatever lies in her power to father her offspring.”

Related Characters: Susan Barton (speaker), Mr. Foe

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 130

Explanation and Analysis

After a tumultuous evening filled with debates over who the young girl really is, Foe invites Susan into his bed—and she, confused but curious, accepts. In this exchange, Susan recounts taking a dominant position in the romantic encounter, as she climbs on top of Foe when they make love.

As Susan acknowledges (and as Foe’s reaction makes clear), this kind of sexual positioning was unusual for a woman of this era. But for Susan, the only thing that is exciting about sex with Mr. Foe is the opportunity to gain some control; as she confesses, not until she gains power does she lose her “listlessness.” And because this dominance allows Susan to understand herself as “the Muse,” a reference to the ancient Greek goddess who would inspire men to write, she once more links artistic creation to carnal procreation.

The other startling detail in this bedroom scene is the way that Susan identifies herself as the “father” of her “offspring” (in this case, the narrative of her time on the island). Again, sex and storytelling are conjoined, and again, both are avenues through which Susan can gain some of the power typically denied to her. But also, by calling herself a father, Susan opens the door to the fact that the young girl might be “father-born” and still her daughter. After all, it wouldn’t be the first time Susan has used words to manipulate the truth.

“You say,” he said—and I woke up with a start—“you say he was guiding his boat to the place where the ship went down, which we may surmise to have been a slave ship, not a merchant man, as Cruso claimed. Well, then; picture the hundreds of his fellow slaves—or their skeletons—still chained in the wreck, the gay little fish (that you spoke of) flitting through their eye sockets and the hollow cases that had held their hearts. Picture Friday above, staring down upon them, casting buds and petals that float a brief while, then sink to settle among the bones of the dead... in every story there is a silence, some sight concealed, some word unspoken, I believe. Until we have spoken the unspoken we have not come to the heart of the story.

Related Characters: Mr. Foe (speaker), Susan Barton, Friday

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 132

Explanation and Analysis

While Susan and Foe lie in bed together, Foe begins to dig into the meaning of Friday’s petal-scattering ritual. For the first time in the entire novel, Mr. Foe connects the dots: it does not follow that Friday and Cruso would have been together on a merchant ship, but it does make sense that they might have been on a slave ship. So Cruso was a slave trader, and Friday was being held in bondage as the ship crossed the dreaded Middle Passage. The “sight concealed,” the “unspoken” reality at the “heart” of this story, is the tragedy of slavery.

More than that, Mr. Foe makes clear that Friday is in mourning, and that the petals are an act of commemoration, honoring the loss of hundreds of lives. This new perspective makes so many aspects of the story make sense: why Friday sometimes falls into his “mopes”; why Cruso, as an enslaver, would make such casual, cruel statements about “Providence” being unequal; even the location of the island, stuck in the middle of the Atlantic, becomes clear in the context of the slave trade.

Symbolically, too, it is worth noting the trajectory of the petals: they start on the surface, and Susan observes them there and then leaves them alone. But once the petals travel underneath the surface, they reveal a much darker story of loss and resilience.

“If we devote ourselves to finding holes exactly shaped to house such great words as *Freedom*, *Honor*, *Bliss*, I agree, we shall spend a lifetime slipping and sliding and searching, and all in vain. They are words without a home, wanders like the planets, and that is an end of it. But you must ask yourself, Susan; as it was a slaver’s stratagem to rob Friday of his tongue, may it not be a slaver’s stratagem to hold him in subjection while we cavil over words in a dispute we know to be endless?”

“Friday is no more in subjection than my shadow is for following me around. He is not free, but he is not in subjection. He is his own master, in law, and has been since Cruso’s death.”

“Nevertheless, Friday follows you: you do not follow Friday. The words you have written and hung around his neck say he is set free; but who, looking at Friday, will believe them?”

Related Characters: Susan Barton, Mr. Foe (speaker), Friday, Cruso

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 140

Explanation and Analysis

Mr. Foe is shocked that in all their time together, Susan has not made a real effort to teach Friday how to write—and he insists that if he is going to continue to support her, she has to get serious about building a language with Friday. But Susan prefers to go in circles on the nature of language itself, doing here in miniature what she has done the entire novel. Mr. Foe calls this out as a “slaver’s stratagem”: by questioning the meanings and uses of words, Susan gets around the undeniable, physical realities of inequality. Or, as Mr. Foe points out, no matter what Susan says, she cannot fight the fact that “Friday follows you: you do not follow Friday.” At the same time, debating over language as a way of delaying action is by no means unique to Susan; one needs only to read the Founding Fathers’ Federalist Papers to understand that this is a thinly veiled critique of many European (and later American) colonizers.

There is one more small but critical detail here. Mr. Foe notes that Susan has written words and hung them around Friday’s neck; just a few pages later, it will be revealed that there is a scar on Friday’s neck, something Susan never mentioned before. Symbolically, then, do Susan’s words harm Friday, even when she claims to be “benevolent?”

“But since we speak of childbearing, has the time not come to tell me the truth about your own child, the lost daughter and Bahia? Did you truly give birth to her? Is she substantial or is she a story too?”

“I will answer, but not before you have told me: the girl you send who calls herself by my name, is she substantial? You touch her; you embrace her; you kiss her. Would you dare to say she’s not substantial? No, she is substantial, as my daughter is substantial and I am substantial; and you two are substantial, no less and no more than any of us. We are all alive, we are all substantial, we are all in the same world.”

“You have omitted Friday.”

Related Characters: Susan Barton, Mr. Foe (speaker), Friday, Young girl

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 142

Explanation and Analysis

In this final exchange between Susan and Mr. Foe, Susan seems to backhandedly admit that the story of her daughter is perhaps not what she has led Mr. Foe to believe. Rather than answering definitively, Susan merely goes on a tangent about how all people are “substantial.” This strange response suggests that Susan is just as much a puppet-master of her life as Mr. Foe is: maybe her daughter is a real person with whom she has no relationship, or maybe it is the young girl she denies. Either way, Susan is inventing—her only two criteria for a “substantial” being are that they can be “kissed” and written about, born through art and sex.

But most importantly, when Susan goes through her laundry of who is “substantial,” she “omits” Friday. By simply pointing out that omission, Mr. Foe gets to one of the central arguments of the novel named after him: omission can be violence when it denies someone personhood.

Part 4 Quotes

●● But this is not a place of words. Each syllable, as it comes out, is caught and filled with water and diffused. This is a place where bodies have their own signs. It is the home of Friday.

He turns and turns till he lies at full length, his face to my face. The skin is tight across his bones, his lips are drawn back. I pass a fingernail across his teeth, trying to find a way in.

His mouth opens. From inside him comes a slow stream, without breath, without interruption. It flows up through his body and out upon me; it passes through the cabin, through the wreck; washing the cliffs and shores of the island, it runs northward and southward to the ends of the earth. Soft and cold, dark and unending, it beats against my eyelids, against the skin of my face.

Related Characters: Susan Barton, Friday

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 149

Explanation and Analysis

In this disorienting, short, final section, an unnamed

narrator—who seems at once to be both Susan and someone much more contemporary—dives under the water, into the shipwreck that Friday and Cruso survived. In this place, written “words” pale before the physical reality of “bodies,” most of them drowned and chained.

This complicated passage, written in a more modern and almost poetic kind of prose, willfully defies easy interpretation. The focus on “signs” that communicate meaning beyond language reflects the book’s postmodern sensibility, which calls into question language as a tool of manipulation and oppression. What is clear, though, is that this the first time Friday’s perspective has ever been given real weight (even if his perspective is physically forced out of him by the narrator’s “fingernail”).

And when Friday’s story does come, even in this nonlinguistic form, it overwhelms the novel so much that this is the very last line—what Friday has to say cannot be contained within the pages of Coetzee’s novel, so it breaks the book off. The “face” this story beats against, then, is as much Susan’s as it is Coetzee’s; maybe it even belongs to Coetzee’s readers. Friday’s story, a story of erasure and loss and continuation against all odds, is everywhere (“the ends of the earth”) and “unending”—so whenever and wherever *Foe* is opened, that story will continue to “beat.”



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

PART 1

“At last I could row no further,” Susan Barton declares—so adrift at sea, arms tired from rowing, she jumps in the water and swims. She eventually makes it to an **island**, where she collapses, petticoats and all. Before she can sleep, though, she looks up to see “a Negro man” (Friday).

Susan is hopeful that this man will save her life, but when she asks him for water in Portuguese, he does not respond. Immediately, noticing the spear by Friday’s side, Susan begins to fear that he is a cannibal; when he touches her skin, Susan panics that he is imagining what it would be like to eat her. No such thing happens, though, and eventually, Susan mimes her thirst so that Friday understands.

Friday leads Susan across the **island**, up a steep hill. At one point, Susan gets a thorn in her ankle, and Friday (who is shorter than Susan) has to carry her on his back. Susan notices that Friday can walk over these thorns without seeming to be in pain. Neither of them speaks the entire journey.

Susan describes the island, which she makes clear has nothing to do with the romantic places described in “travellers’ tales.” On this island, there are ants like the ones Susan encountered in Bahia, plus seaweed that gives off a terrible stench. The bushes are “drab” and do not flower, though there are all kinds of animals (apes, lizards, birds, and dolphins). Susan reflects that if animals were enough for her, she could be content—“but who,” she wonders, “accustomed to the fullness of human speech, can be content with caws and chirps”?

The first sentence of Susan’s narrative makes several things clear. First, this is a story told through Susan’s eyes; all we have access to is her first-person narration. Second, the language Susan uses shows that she is writing several hundred years ago. And perhaps most importantly, Susan opens her story at a very unnatural place: in the middle of the ocean, without explaining how she got there.



Susan’s initial reaction to Friday reflects her deeply ingrained racism: all she knows about this person is that he is Black, but immediately, she conflates his race with violence and (crucially) cannibalism. In reality, of course, Friday is patient and eager to help Susan quench her thirst.



The fact that Friday does not feel the thorns in his feet suggests that he has been on this island long enough to grow physically accustomed to its harsh landscape. This image of Friday carrying Susan on his back will later recur, as it becomes an easy symbol of slavery for Susan.



Even though Susan is writing a travel narrative, she is aware of the flaws with the form: such “tales” tend to exaggerate and romanticize the unappealing, boring reality of travel. It is also important to note that Susan’s devotion to the “fullness” of language; she struggles to relate to the other creatures on the island because she believes that language is the central ingredient of understanding and companionship.



At the top of the hill, Susan can look out on the whole ocean, where she notices the boat that brought her to this **island** sailing away. She realizes that she is in a small encampment, and that another European man is present. She speaks to this new stranger in Portuguese, and he informs her that he speaks English. Susan comments on the man's strange garb: long underwear like watermen wear on the Thames, and a tall, conic, fur cap. Meanwhile, Friday brings Susan water, and Susan drinks it greedily.

Susan explains that the crew of the nearby ship mutinied and killed their captain, casting her adrift with the captain's dead body. Recalling the spear stuck through the captain's eye, Susan breaks down into tears. The stranger watches her, and Susan tells her audience that he is "of course the Cruso I told you about."

Susan now goes into detail about the encampment. In the center of two big rocks, Cruso had built himself a hut. Beyond the hut, Cruso had erected a leather barrier, fencing off a triangle of land that he calls his "castle." Within the fence, Cruso grows wild lettuce, which Susan explains is—along with fish and eggs—the only thing they eat on the island.

Cruso gives Susan a handmade needle to help her take the thorn out of her foot. While she extracts it, Susan tells Cruso her story: she was born to a Frenchman and an Englishwoman, and she was raised in England. Two years earlier, her only daughter had been kidnapped and brought to the New World. Susan traveled to Bahia, Brazil, to find her daughter, but was given no help from the Brazilian government and so failed in her mission.

At last, Susan had given up, and had booked passage on a merchant's ship back to Lisbon. But ten days into that journey, the crew had mutinied, stranding Susan here. She reflects that she does not know why she was cast away by the crew, other than that people often start to hate those they have abused.

Having finished her story, Susan now becomes Cruso's "second subject"; the first is Friday, whom Susan now knows is Cruso's manservant. Susan tells her reader that she wishes she could supply Cruso's backstory, but the stories he told her were so contradictory that she thinks even Cruso himself does not know what is real and what is fantasy.

For the first time, readers begin to understand that Susan was intentionally left on this island—which makes her earlier omission of that fact more suspicious. From his language and dress, it is clear that this new man Susan has encountered is from England (the Thames is a river in London).



The gaps in Susan's story now become even more apparent—why did the crew want her off their ship, in addition to the captain? And even more interestingly, who is Susan talking to? Clearly, her story is addressed to one person in particular, and it is someone she knows well (as she has already told this person about Cruso prior to the start of this narrative).



Like Friday, Cruso has been on the island for a while (or at least long enough to build this expansive encampment). Once again, Susan's detailed description of the island reveals it to be a less interesting place than typical travel narratives would suggest.



Though the loss of her daughter is dramatic, the stuff of juicy stories, Susan is unwilling to dwell on it (either in her narrative or, apparently, in her conversation with Cruso). Later, as Susan tries to find material to enliven her tale, her refusal to reveal more information about her daughter will get in the way of her authorial ambitions.



The clues are tricky to spot, but it is becoming harder to ignore that Susan is a somewhat unreliable narrator. Rather than questioning why the ship's crew might distrust her, Susan paints herself as an "abused" victim of others' ill will.



There are no laws on this island, much less a government, yet Cruso still rules, keeping Susan and Friday as his "subjects." This hierarchy reflects broader racial and gender hierarchies; even on a remote island, the white man (Cruso) has more power than his Black or female counterparts.



Sometimes, Cruso says he was born rich, while other times he claims to be an orphan who had been captured by Moors. He also tells different stories about Friday: he says sometimes that Friday was a “little slave-boy” when they met, sometimes that Friday was a cannibal. Susan fears that the cannibals will one day return for Friday, and Cruso acknowledges that this is a possibility.

While they eat, Susan wonders aloud why Cruso has never tried to escape. Cruso explains that they are hundreds of miles from Brazil, the nearest shore—and even if they did get to Brazil, he argues, it is “full of cannibals.” Privately, Susan begins to understand that life on an island has narrowed Cruso’s worldview, and that he will never have any real desire to leave.

Cruso offers Susan his bed, but she refuses, instead sleeping on a nearby mat. Though she struggles to fall asleep, haunted by her change in circumstances, she eventually grows calm. When she wakes the next morning, it is raining hard. For the next several days, the weather alternates endlessly back-and-forth between wind and rain. More than the loneliness or the strange diet, Susan feels that the wind is unbearable.

In addition to the encampment, Cruso has made himself several tools. One of these is a knife, saved from his own shipwreck, which he tells Susan to use for protection against the apes; though the apes avoid Friday and himself, Cruso thinks they will not fear Susan because she is a woman. Susan is skeptical of this. The other tools, wooden bowls and a spade, have all been crafted from the wood and stone on the **island**. Susan laments that Cruso does not have better tools with which to plan an escape.

There is also a stove in Cruso’s hut, and some treated ape skins. Tellingly, however, there is no journal or pen. Susan does not understand why Cruso does not want to write things down, and thus preserve a record of his time on the **island**; after all, as she points out, memory is faulty. But Cruso insists that “nothing I have forgotten is worth the remembering.”

This logic upsets Susan, who insists that without the inclusion of everyday details, “life begins to lose its particularities”—how could an outsider believe Cruso’s story is true and his own if he does not write down the details? Susan even suggests some ways that Cruso could make writing implements, but Cruso stands firm, telling her that the only thing he wants to leave behind are his **terraces** and walls.

Again, Susan speculates about whether Friday is a cannibal. But crucially, this time cannibalism acts as a cover story for the much more likely reality: namely, that Friday was enslaved and that he was not a source of brutality but a victim of it. Continually, then, Susan seems to manipulate the boundaries between victim and victimizer.



Even as Susan manipulates reality in her own narrative, she is critical of Cruso when he does the exact same thing. Cruso claims to be afraid of escaping, but actually, he just has grown accustomed to the shapelessness and freedom of his island days.



One of the most important contrasts Susan draws is between the adventure-filled “traveller’s tales” and the boring, repetitive truth of her time on the island. The nonstop wind illustrates this monotony: rather than the chatter and bustle of urban life (whether in London or Bahia), on the island there is only one endless, meaningless sound.



Cruso believes gender differences are so essential that even the apes will pick up on them, but Susan is not so sure. Instead, she begins to wonder if gender is a socialized idea, created by human norms and behavior as opposed to existing in nature.



In this vital exchange, Susan begins to understand just how different she and Cruso are. Whereas Cruso is dedicated to making life on the island as comfortable as it can possibly be, Susan merely wants to record her life and get away, sucking a good story out of this remote locale and then leaving it behind.



Both Susan and Cruso are interested in building a legacy, but the legacies they are interested in are very different. Susan wants to make a name for herself to those beyond the island, but Cruso wants to be remembered on the island, for any future inhabitants that may (or may not) come.



At night, Susan still sleeps near Cruso, using ape skins as blankets. She does not like the smell of the ape skins or the sound of Cruso grinding his teeth, but Susan is proud that her time in Bahia has taught her to be less “dainty.” Sometimes, she dreams of the murdered ship captain.

One day, Susan explores the **island** against Cruso’s wishes. When she returns, he is angry at her for disobeying him—but she replies that she is “a castaway, not a prisoner.” Later that evening, Susan asks Cruso for a needle and thread to make shoes, but he tells her to be patient. Days pass, and Susan still does not have any shoes.

A while later, Susan tries telling Friday to bring more wood. Friday stands, but does nothing, and Cruso explains that he only knows the word “firewood,” not the word “wood.” Cruso also tells Susan that Friday knows very few words of English, which upsets Susan, who thinks that language is the key to civilization and happiness. Instead of answering, Cruso just instructs Friday to sing, which he does.

Cruso then shocks Susan by saying that Friday cannot speak—he has had his **tongue** cut out by “slavers.” Susan wonders why anyone would do this, and Cruso gives three possibilities: maybe the slavers view tongue as a delicacy, maybe they didn’t want to hear Friday cry in grief, or maybe they were punishing him for his cannibalism. Susan is frightened that Cruso seems to be smiling as he says all of this.

Susan becomes obsessed by Friday’s mutilated **tongue**, and she finds it increasingly difficult to be around him without thinking about the horrible act. She wonders why Providence has dealt Friday so terrible a hand, and Cruso replies that “if Providence were to watch over all of us...who would be left to pick the cotton and cut the sugarcane?”

Tired of waiting for Cruso, Susan eventually makes herself shoes. Unsurprisingly, Cruso is annoyed by this, and the two get into a fight. After a few hours, Susan remembers that her position on the **island** is precarious, and she apologizes to Cruso. That night, she feels some measure of real joy when she begins to feel the ground swaying beneath her, proof that she is on an island.

Susan’s romantic life is complicated and mysterious (and will remain as such). But it is evident that she feels some sort of attachment to the murdered captain, dreaming about him even weeks later. And there is also an almost-romantic intimacy in the way she shares space with Cruso, packed close even on a large, deserted, island.



Just as Susan questions Cruso’s claims about the apes’ sexism, she now begins to doubt the rigid power structures (implicitly based on gender and race) that Cruso enforces.



In his interactions with Friday, Cruso uses language—and its absence—as a tool he can use to assert dominance. Because Cruso does not try to impart real understanding to Friday of what wood or firewood is, the words become purely orders, a way of bending Friday to his will. Susan is critical of this—and at the same time, she refuses to give any real credence to one of Friday’s other forms of expression: his singing.



Friday’s missing tongue will become one of the most important symbols in the novel. As Cruso presents it, it once again shows how Cruso (and Susan) prefer to turn Friday into an object of fear rather than acknowledging the brutality of his enslavement; mutilating is a horrific act, but Cruso smiles through it, painting it as a fitting punishment for Friday’s (made-up) cannibalism.



Cruso’s statement here is a tacit endorsement of slavery and all of its evils: he is prioritizing the economic gains of slavery over the bodily and emotional evils it entails. Though Susan distances herself from Cruso on other issues, tellingly, she does not push back against this sentiment.



*Susan has only been on the island for a short time, but already, she is beginning to understand Cruso’s acceptance of this deserted place. Throughout *Foe*, islands often symbolize loneliness or disconnection, so Susan’s new joy about the swaying ground signals that she is seeing the virtues of isolation.*



Now that Susan has shoes, she starts walking all over the **island**, feeling herself slip into a kind of “waking slumber.” Though Susan sometimes pushes for change—for example, suggesting candles so that they can have light after the sun goes down—Cruso will not stand for any of it. Susan begins to crave a space that feels like hers, even though she knows that the island does not actually belong to Cruso.

A month into Susan’s stay, Cruso comes back to the hut feeling ill (“it is the old fever that came with me,” he explains). For 12 days and nights, Susan take care of Cruso, who is often overcome by fits of raving. Meanwhile, Friday avoids the hut, only catching and scaling fish for Susan and playing his flute. Once, Susan gets so sick of hearing the flute play that she grabs it out of Friday’s hands, much to his surprise.

Cruso seems to be feeling better, until a giant storm sweeps the island, and he descends back into fever. Between Cruso’s ravings—he keeps saying the word “Massa”—and Friday’s flute-playing, Susan begins to feel like she is in “a madhouse.” As the rain starts to slow down, Susan stretches her body across Cruso’s, hoping to keep him warm and save his life.

That night, Susan wakes to find that Cruso is touching her sexually, which makes her think of the Portuguese captain. Susan considers resisting, but then feels bad that Cruso has not had sexual relations with a woman in so many years, so she gives in. She does not know whether or not this was the right choice.

Days later, Susan is out for a walk when she notices an unusual occurrence. Though she has seen Friday on the water fishing many times, she has never seen him go out to sea for non-fishing purposes. But now, he is spreading petals on the water, which to Susan is the “first sign that a spirit or soul...stirred beneath that dull and unpleasing exterior.”

Susan’s isolationism continues as, despite her already limited amount of human contact, she seeks even more independence from her companions. Her “waking slumber” could suggest that Susan is struggling with depression—but since she is writing in the early 18th century, she lacks the language to describe such a condition.



Cruso’s backstory remains mysterious—but unlike with Friday, Susan does not speculate on it. Also worth noting is the fact that, once again, Susan disregards or is frustrated by Friday’s preferred form of expression (music).



The strange word “Massa” is probably a link to Más a Tierra, an island off the coast of Chile where Alexander Selkirk—the real-life inspiration for Robinson Crusoe, the protagonist of Daniel Defoe’s novel of the same name—was marooned. Today, Más a Tierra has been renamed Robinson Crusoe Island in honor of Defoe’s novel. It’s also worth noting that “Massa” sounds like the word “master,” which perhaps says something about Cruso’s past, the possibility that he has been an enslaver, and the nature of his relationship with Friday.



This kind of sexual contact (outside of wedlock) would have been scandalous for the period, but Susan does not dwell on it, even as she hopes for more scandals to write about. Moreover, this is the first time that Susan reveals her sexual history with the murdered ship captain; perhaps it was this loyalty to the captain that made the crew cast her out during the mutiny.



The mysterious petals will be important throughout the book: are they an act of artistic creation? A kind of mourning or commemoration? Either way, Susan intuitively that the petals are important, even as she continues to make profoundly anti-Black assessments of Friday (denying him a “spirit” because of judgments on his “exterior”).



When Susan pushes Cruso to go back into his wrecked ship and look for tools, Cruso refuses. Instead, he remains dead set on building out his **terraces**: patches of ground that have been levelled and cleared and reinforced with stone. But to Susan's surprise, Cruso does not plan to plant anything on his terraces. Rather, the planting is reserved for future visitors to the island. Cruso proudly tells Susan that though he is a castaway by circumstance, he is not a castaway "at heart."

Susan grows frustrated by Cruso's irrational behavior, and by his refusal to write or look for tools or even have a real conversation with her. She reflects that even if Cruso is to be rescued, his story will be boring and unsatisfying to the masses, who are hungry for more exciting adventure tales. For a time, Susan goes into a "lethargy," tying furs around her face so she cannot hear and moaning in discontent.

Eventually, Susan comes out of her despair, and is able to return to life with Cruso and Friday. Though Cruso never touches her again, she tells her reader that if she had stayed on the **island** much longer, she would have wanted to have a child with Cruso—she could not bear this lonely silence much longer.

Susan also begins to become curious about what kind of laws exist on the **island**. When she asks Cruso about it, he insists that there are no laws. Susan fears that without laws, they could all be cruel or tyrannical to each other—yet they are not. Cruso explains that he does not believe in any sort of punishment, which causes Susan to reflect that perhaps being on the island forever is punishment enough.

Sometimes, however, Susan views Cruso with more admiration. After all, if her first days on the **island** were so difficult, how terrible must it have been for Cruso? She is impressed that he can find so much meaning from sea and sky, which to her feel empty.

About a year after Susan's arrival on the island, Cruso becomes sick again—and this time, his illness seems deadly. But as if by fate, a ship headed to Bristol (the "John Hobart") passes by the **island**. The travelers agree to take Susan and Cruso back to England, and Susan ensures that they do not forget Friday, either.

The terraces reveal important new information about Cruso: though he has previously seemed unfriendly and detached, he does desire to give back to his island home somehow (even if the terraces without crops lack logic). By saying he is not a castaway "at heart," Cruso is suggesting that the norms of community and society still matter to him.



In contrast to Cruso, who wants to improve their island home, Susan wants only to escape the island, converting their time there into a story with mass appeal. In other words, both Susan and Cruso want to leave a legacy, but Susan is more extractive and more interested in gaining something tangible from this experience.



Susan seems to link childbearing less with sexual desire and more with the desire to create—to have more people to speak with. Throughout the novel, Susan will continue to conflate childbearing with other forms of linguistic creation.



Susan's curiosity about the laws is perhaps another way in which she questions the default power structures in London and Bahia; if there are no laws, why do she and Friday still defer to Cruso as their leader?



Just like any avid reader of "traveller's tales," Susan is hungry for juicy stories and intricate detail. But Cruso finds meaning instead from the massive blankness of sea and sky, from the very lack of detail and human interest in the natural world.



Susan's decision to bring Friday deprives Friday of agency; even though he cannot speak, Susan could try to figure out what he actually wants. The 'John Hobart' ship is named for a famous British politician.



While the crew looks for Friday, Susan and the captain, Captain Smith, share a delicious dinner. The captain suggests that Susan should write down her story, as there has never been a female castaway. But Susan assures him that her time on the **island** was boring, not good enough for a book to be written.

At last, Friday is found and brought to the ship. Friday is confused and afraid of these new circumstances, but Susan does her best to comfort him, making her voice warm even though they do not share language. Susan sleeps in Cruso's cabin, and she pleads that Friday should sleep on the floor in front of the cabin: he would rather sleep there, she argues, "than on the softest bed in Christendom."

The doctors come every day to let Cruso's blood and try to cure his fever, but to no avail. Meanwhile, Captain Smith persuades Susan to tell everyone that she and Cruso are married so as to avoid uncomfortable questions. Susan does so and tries not to notice when the captain propositions her one night over dinner.

Eventually, Susan comes to believe that Cruso is dying of woe at having been separated from their **island**. She lies next to him and calls him "my Cruso"; she reminds him of the stars on the island, and wonders if they were "nearer the heavens" there. Susan begins to touch and lick and lie on Cruso, as if she is "swimming" in him. Sometimes, she fantasizes about returning to the island with a sack of corn to finally plant Cruso's **terraces**.

Three days out from England, Cruso dies. The crew holds a small funeral, and Susan wonders if Friday is capable of understanding what death is. Susan wonders what the crew makes of her—and then she wonders what Mr. Foe, the "you" she has been addressing her tale to, makes of her. Ultimately, though, Susan realizes that it doesn't matter what Mr. Foe thinks: "it is I who have disposal of all that Cruso leaves behind," Susan brags, "which is the story of his **island**."

Susan has made it clear that she intends to use her experiences for a book of some kind, so it is revealing that she does not want to center herself—just as she does not reveal details to her reader about her daughter or her time in Bahia. It seems ever more likely that Susan is obscuring something from her own past.



Just as she forces Friday onto the ship, Susan now forces Friday into discomfort (sleeping on the floor instead of a bed). This paternalistic logic reflects much of the discourse around slavery as a whole at the time, which dictated that slavery was a "positive good," as white people could "educate" the Black people they enslaved.



Bloodletting was an early modern practice in which doctors would take blood from their patients, believing that by ridding the body of contaminated blood, it could heal faster. Susan's instinct to not sleep with the captain perhaps reflects her previous experience, when she slept with the Portuguese captain and then was cast off the ship for doing so.



In this strange scene, Susan starts to experience the sexual desire for Cruso she never actually felt on the island; for her, it seems that Cruso has become the personification of the island itself (she can "swim" in him, suggesting he has become, physically, like their ocean). Similarly, Susan's newfound resolution to plant the terraces suggests that for the first time, she wants to give back to the island just as Cruso did.



There are two key things to take away from this passage. First, Susan has been telling her story to Mr. Foe—her name for Daniel Defoe, or the real-life author who would ultimately go on to publish the 1719 novel [Robinson Crusoe](#). Second, Susan seems aware of her newfound power as an eyewitness and narrator—the island may have belonged to Cruso, but she has sole ownership over the "story" of that island.



PART 2

It is April 15th, and Susan—now going by Mrs. Cruso—and Friday have settled in London. In a letter to Mr. Foe, Susan explains that she is attaching the whole history of her time on the **island** to this letter; since she has no money and needs to pay for her lodgings, anything Mr. Foe could send would be helpful. Susan admits that her story is monotonous, but she trusts that Mr. Foe can make it better, given that he has made a living turning people's confessions into art.

On April 20th, Susan thanks Mr. Foe for the three guineas he has sent her, which she has used to buy new clothes. Susan is working as Mr. Foe's servant, and she wishes that Mr. Foe would just take her and Friday into his home. Susan brings Mr. Foe breakfast in the attic room where he works, and notices how carefully he protects his writing papers, so that they will not be disturbed by mice. Among the papers are notes about ghosts, remarks on the wool trade, and a story of someone named Dickory Cronke.

Though Susan spent her whole time on the **island** wanting to leave, she is surprised to find that she now misses it dearly. She wishes she had saved sand or some other memento from the island (all she has is her shoes). Susan also expresses regret that she spent so much time telling Mr. Foe about Cruso, and so little describing her own life. "I was as much a body," Susan reflects, "I ate and drank, I woke, and slept, I longed." Susan wonders if it is impossible to tell your story when you are in the middle of it; maybe you need a desk and a window to imagine a place rather than actually being there.

Now it is April 21st, and Susan, worrying that her last letter mocked the art of writing, apologizes to Mr. Foe. She tries to picture his life, wondering if he has a wife or children; she imagines how difficult it is to imagine places you have never been to and describe them. She wishes she could help Mr. Foe access what it felt like to be on that **island**.

On April 25th, Susan tells Mr. Foe (via another letter) everything she knows about Cruso's shipwreck, which she believes took place on the north side of the **island**. Susan discusses the difficulty of bringing anything from the ship onto the island through the waves, even potentially lifesaving tools. Susan also asserts that, contrary to Cruso's claim, she does not believe there are any cannibals in the ocean.

Now, the purpose of Part One becomes clear: Susan is telling her tale to the prominent author Mr. Foe (Daniel Defoe) in the hopes that he can jazz it up a little. Susan aims for monetary gain from her story, but she also seems to yearn for the more attention-getting (and enduring) path of having her life turned into art.



Mr. Foe is paying for Susan and Friday's lives, which suggests that he does think there is real promise in their story. The other papers Susan sees are all references to real Daniel Defoe books (for example, Dickory Cronke is the hero in Defoe's text Dickory Cronke, The Dumb Philosopher).



Not for the last time, Susan begins to be frustrated that by making herself a minor character in her own narrative, she has shortchanged her own "substance." But in this rare moment of reflection, Susan also begins to understand that no one can tell a complete, objective, version of their own story; sometimes, more insight comes from a writer's empathetic imagination than a person's lived experience.



Even as Susan turns the tale of her life over to Mr. Foe, she is also narrating a version of his story. It is ironic that while Susan laments the difficulty of telling stories she hasn't lived, she is doing just that about the Foe family. Throughout, the novel emphasizes the parallelism of Susan and Mr. Foe as equal storytellers in their own right.



It is important to note that Susan does not really believe there were any cannibals on the island (including Friday), as she will later go back on this claim. It is also worth paying attention to Susan's rigid dating of her letters: now that she is back in London, Susan is able to follow a calendar in a way she could not do on the island.



Last night, Susan dreamed of Cruso's death and woke with tears in her eyes; she fears that he is going to be forgotten, and that his walls and **terraces** will be taken as the structures of cannibals. Susan resolves to make sketches of some of the things Cruso left behind on the **island**.

Because Cruso did not write anything down, he will not control the narrative that attaches itself to his terraces. Implicitly, Susan is suggesting that writing is the most surefire way to protect one's legacy.



While Susan mourns, Friday seems to sleep most of the day away, feeling too afraid of his new surroundings to go outside. Still, the rumor has gotten around that there is a cannibal nearby, as all the neighborhood boys have come to gawk at him. Susan resolves to teach Friday how to do laundry, and again laments that Cruso never taught Friday language; couldn't they have come up with a system of pebbles or hand gestures so that Friday could communicate even without a **tongue**?

Someone spread the rumor that Friday was a cannibal—it had to be Mr. Foe or Susan. But the prevalence of this rumor wherever Friday goes then demonstrates how pervasive the racist stereotype of cannibalism was at this time.



Susan tries to teach Friday some basic words (like “spoon” and “fork”), though she fears he will never be able to learn language, since he has spent so much of his life without it. She also comments on how different Friday seems than he did on the **island**: there he was strong and agile, and in England, he just eats oatmeal and lies around.

Though Susan claims to be different than Cruso in her approach to communication with Friday, the words she teaches him are just as mercenary as “firewood.” Instead of introducing Friday to words that would actually help him have conversations, Susan is just trying to make Friday into a more efficient servant.



One day, Susan tries to teach Friday about Mr. Foe and the kinds of books he writes. Susan explains that if Mr. Foe writes about their time on the **island**, they will become rich, and Friday will be able to go home to his family in Africa or Brazil. Though she reads Friday passages from other books Mr. Foe has written and tries to get him excited about the idea that Mr. Foe's book could preserve his life story forever, Friday pays no attention.

What is the true nature of Susan's relationship with Mr. Foe? Her determination to have this particular person write her story has never made sense, but now it seems that Susan is actually a devoted fan of Mr. Foe's work—and that she wants her own life to exist alongside those of her favorite literary characters.



Susan starts to be more and more upset by how much of her life she lives in silence. She begs Mr. Foe to let her and Friday come over to the garden at his house in Stoke Newington, as she can tell that Friday misses the feeling of soft ground beneath his feet. She hopes that maybe through gardening, she and Friday will be able to establish some kind of language with each other.

It is important to note every time Susan expresses a desire on Friday's behalf. More often than not, she is rerouting her own desire through this silenced man, using his lack of a tongue to get her way (without having to explicitly ask for what she wants herself).



Lost in her daydream about gardening with Friday, Susan starts to wonder why using language with this man is so important to her. Is it because she really wants to communicate with him? Or is it because words allow her to boss Friday around, in the same way that Cruso could? Susan admits, not without shame, that Friday makes her understand “why a man will choose to be a slaveowner.” On April 28th, Susan notes that the letter about gardening has been returned to her unopened.

Early on in her time in London, Susan is able to catch herself when she sees that she is falling into the behaviors of a “slaveowner”; though she does not seem opposed to the practice of slavery as a whole, she does not herself want to be seen as responsible for it.



It's May 1st, and Susan has just returned from Stoke Newington to find that Mr. Foe has fled and that the bailiffs are watching his house. She is worried about Mr. Foe's safety, but relieved to know that he has not been ignoring her letters. Susan also fears that while he is in hiding from the law, Mr. Foe will no longer send money to her and Friday.

A week later, there are no real updates: Susan has been dropping her letters off with Mrs. Thrush, Mr. Foe's maid, who confesses that she fears for Mr. Foe's safety. The bailiff Wilkes and his companion have made themselves comfortable in Stoke Newington, and they are adamant that they will not leave until their warrant is served. If Mr. Foe comes back, he will likely be sent to the Fleet, a notorious prison—becoming one of a number of “castaways in the very heart of the city.” Susan learns that Mr. Foe has been widowed for many years.

Returning home, Susan feels that she can no longer bear all of the stress and anxiety of Mr. Foe and the bailiffs and Friday. She begs Mr. Foe to finish his book, so that she and Friday will have money to travel to far-off places; if Susan could finish her memoir in three days, what is taking Mr. Foe so long with his work?

It is now May 19th, and Susan is increasingly desperate. Flowers have begun to bloom, and yet Susan and Friday have not received any more money. When Susan goes to Stoke Newington, she sees that Mrs. Thrush is gone and the doors are boarded up.

Ten days later, Susan writes another letter to Mr. Foe informing him that she and Friday have taken up residence in his home. Susan is surprised to find that the space is much as she had pictured it: “does it surprise you as much as it does me,” she asks Mr. Foe, “this correspondence between the way things are and the pictures we have of them in our minds?”

Susan assures Mr. Foe that she and Friday are being careful with his linens and plates, and that Friday has set to work restoring his garden. She fears that Mr. Foe has gone to the colonies, but though she confesses to having felt some resentment at his abandonment in the past, Susan now feels comfortable and warm towards him in Stoke Newington. Strangely, she remarks, the house feels as if it were her own childhood home.

In real life, Daniel Defoe was charged and arrested for seditious libel—meaning that he was taken to jail for supposedly spreading lies in his stories. In a way, then, the bailiffs at Mr. Foe's house are a physical manifestation of the dangers of embellishment.



Just as islands are an important symbol throughout the novel of loneliness, here, Susan reflects that it is possible to be “castaway” (put on a metaphorical island) even in the middle of a dense, urban, metropolis like London. One of the recurring ideas throughout the novel is that loneliness is possible anywhere—but while it is easy for Susan to talk about the loneliness of a desert island, it is harder for her to talk about feeling isolated in the “heart of the city.”



This is another odd detail about Susan—she wanted so badly to leave the island, but now she wants to travel again. Why does Susan have no family or community she wants to return home to?



The natural world is thriving, but Susan is doing increasingly poorly. This juxtaposition between her internal state and nature reflects that, unlike Crusoe, Susan is not at home in the wild; she prefers artificial, created worlds.



As a burgeoning storyteller, Susan is interested in the ways that writerly imagination can “correspond” to lived reality. Now, she is pleased to see that her picture of Mr. Foe's house matches what it actually looks like—giving her license, perhaps, to trust her imagination more than she previously did.



The mention of the “colonies” is a reminder that this story is set at the height of colonization and slavery—a time that also saw the rise of the novel as a popular form. Susan's comfort in Mr. Foe's home again suggests a parallel between the two figures.



“How much of my life consists in waiting,” Susan reflects. She is trying to write her own narrative now, making a list of all the strange things that happened to her from the mutiny through her rescue on the **island**. Susan wonders if she will invent details: about cannibals come to the shore or about Friday’s backstory.

Susan feels that readers will not be satisfied unless they learn how Friday lost his **tongue**, so she makes two sketches: one that shows Friday’s tongue getting cut out by enslavers, and the other that show Cruso doing the bloody deed. Susan tries to get Friday to tell her which drawing is accurate, but she soon realizes that even this small communication will be impossible.

Moreover, Susan knows that there are many more ways that Friday could have lost his **tongue** than she could ever imagine or draw. Susan tears up her drawings and tells Friday that she feels she is wasting her life on him; “shipwreck is a great leveller,” she scoffs, “but we are not level enough yet.”

On the first day of June, a man named Mr. Summers comes to Mr. Foe’s house; the neighbors had been avoiding the house, so this is the first visitor they have had in months. Susan wonders where Mr. Foe is, and what kind of information he has access to. “The world is full of islands,” Susan reflects, thinking of her own loneliness and of Mr. Foe’s. Sometimes, she thinks that Mr. Foe would prefer to write the story of Cruso’s **island** without her in it at all.

To make things even stranger, a young girl has been watching the house for several days. At last, Susan gives her letters, first for Wilkes and then for Mr. Foe. But the girl claims not to know either of them and instead insists that Susan should recognize her—her name, too, she claims, is Susan Barton.

The young girl tells Susan that she is her mother, and bursts into tears when Susan declares that there is no way she could ever forget her daughter. When Susan presses her, the girl reveals that she knows about the island and Bahia—which makes Susan sure that Mr. Foe has sent her. Angrily, she tells Mr. Foe in her letter that only men could ever forget their children like this.

Susan’s lonely, monotonous life in England mirrors her isolation and boredom on the island. Yet now, Susan could easily find work or some community that might liven her days. The fact that she prefers to find excitement in her tale is meaningful—either Susan is a born storyteller, or she shares some of Cruso’s deep-seated anti-social tendencies.



Susan again only cares to communicate with Friday on her terms, when it will benefit her daily life or her story. Even more importantly, this is the first time—in her suggestion that Cruso might have cut out Friday’s tongue—that Susan begins to consider Cruso’s own role in the brutal slave trading economy.



Though she does not acknowledge it, Susan’s frustration is in part her own fault—she treats Friday as a servant, and then is angry when he is not “level” with her.



In this passage, Susan makes the symbolism of the island explicit, realizing that people like herself and Mr. Foe are lonely all over “the world.” Susan’s prediction that Mr. Foe might write her out of the story proves to be prescient—there is no character named Susan Barton in [Robinson Crusoe](#).



Susan has already begun to question where her reality ends and her story begins—and now, encountering a stranger with her same name, Susan’s sense of self is even more shaken.



Susan and Mr. Foe clearly have a lot in common, but here, Susan zeroes in on the difference between them: as a woman, she feels that children and family are off limits from this kind of narrative manipulation. The difference between mothers and the fathers—and the relationship each has to their progeny—will take on important symbolism throughout the text.



The girl explains that her father was a Brewer in Deptford; Susan is firm that she has never lived in Deptford in her life. The girl also remembers a maid (named either Amy or Emmy), but Susan is confident that she has never had such a servant. Lastly, the girl holds up her hands and eyes to show Susan her physical similarities, but Susan is baffled—none of their features look anything alike.

So much of the value in Susan's story lies in the fact that it is an eyewitness account. In this moment, though, Susan begins to doubt even the veracity of her own eyesight; can she trust what she sees if this girl claims to be her daughter but the visual evidence shows them to look nothing alike?



Susan asks the girl if Mr. Foe sent her, but she gets emotional, repeating that Susan is her true mother. When the girl presses, Susan allows her to stay, and she spends the night in the house, adding details to her backstory (like that she was raised by gypsies after Susan left). Susan tells the girl that these circumstances are impossible: “there are no stories of daughters searching for mothers. There are no stories of such quests because they do not occur.”

By asking the girl if Mr. Foe sent her, Susan is signaling that she thinks the girl is Mr. Foe's attempt to manufacture a happy ending that her story would not otherwise have. In admonishing the young girl, Susan once more blurs the line between story and reality.



Meanwhile, Friday has gone into one of his “mopes,” or the term Cruso once used for his moments of depression. He does not get out of bed for several days, and Susan marvels at her sad situation, wondering if she was wrong to choose Mr. Foe as the teller of their tale. Susan begs Friday to talk to her, describing the need for speech as akin to the need for a kiss or sexual relations.

This is one of many instances in which Susan equates speech and sex—and just as language can lead to a book, sex can lead to childbirth. Moreover, by making this comparison, Susan argues that language is just as primal a human need as sexual contact is.



Susan then begins to wonder if Friday is a virgin; she thinks he is, and that he has probably never been kissed in his life. If Friday stays in England, Susan fears that he will never have any romantic life, since he is unlikely to “meet a woman of his own people” in this country. Susan compares Friday to a dog that, having spent its whole life chained, will not know what to do when he enters the real world. But Susan is also frustrated with herself; she feels that she cannot craft a useful metaphor, and that she is a bad storyteller.

The longer her narrative goes on, the more overtly racist Susan's language becomes. And worse still, after comparing Friday to a dog, Susan frets not about the dehumanizing metaphor but about her lack of artistry as a writer. In addition to being an unreliable narrator, then, Susan is also an unsympathetic one.



Once more, Susan frets that Mr. Foe has died or abandoned them, and that she and Friday will be doomed to a life of poverty and obscurity. She resolves that she cannot write their story herself, as she knows how tedious and monotonous life on the **island** truly was. She wonders aloud whether Friday really was a cannibal, or if it was just a story Cruso made up to break up the boredom of the island.

Now, Susan's earlier assertion that a writer should have distance from their subject matter takes on new meaning—instead of being objective, Susan believes that distance is useful because it allows a writer to lie more easily. Cruso understood this, which is why he shares almost nothing from his own past while making up stories about Friday's.



Thinking back to her time on the **island**, Susan wonders what might be different if instead of just building a bed, Cruso had also built himself a desk and writing implements. But at the same time, Susan knows that “we will never make our fortunes...by being merely what we are”; their story lacks the “spectacle” of cannibals or romance. Susan prepares to go to bed, since night has fallen and they do not have candles here, either—yet another way that her life with Friday in Stoke Newington mirrors their life on the island.

Suddenly, however, Susan is heartened: there was some “mystery” on the **island**. Why was Cruso so obsessed with those fruitless terraces, and how did he and Friday move so many stones when it was just the two of them? How did Friday lose his **tongue**, and was Cruso responsible? Susan muses on the gory details of the mutilation, still horrified, but no longer unable to contemplate it as she once had been.

Susan begins to ask more questions—why did Friday never desire Susan, despite all of the time they’ve spent alone together? (She thinks that this is likely the main question future readers will have.) And most of all, what was Friday doing that day when he threw petals out to sea? Susan acknowledges that though Cruso’s indifference is a hard thing to write a story about, “the sorrows of Friday” are more fertile ground.

Now that she has thought about all these mysteries, Susan is determined to write her own story. She compares writing to the work Friday and Cruso did moving stones around the **island**, though she feels that writing is even more difficult. Before she sets about her task, Susan thinks that perhaps “it is I who have become the slave.”

More days pass, and there is still no word from Mr. Foe. The writing is difficult, because (in Susan’s telling) neither Cruso nor Friday had enough “desire” for an interesting tale. Yet just as a good painter can add drama to an everyday scene, Susan believes that a good writer can do the same: emphasizing power differences, condensing time, and teasing out “hidden meanings” in ordinary events. Had she known she would be writing their tale herself, Susan comments that she would have pressed Cruso harder to “confess” the things he kept secret.

Susan conflates Cruso’s lack of desire to write with laziness, but this outlook ignores the gigantic labor of his terraces; Cruso does believe in the value of hard work, but he is more interested in mysterious future generations than in recording “merely” what he, Susan, and Friday were on the island. After all, as Susan is quickly discovering, life is life—it can be just as boring or repetitive on an island as it is off of it. By that logic, maybe her castaway narrative isn’t as inherently worthwhile as Susan thinks it is.



Susan’s boredom is transforming her worldview. Rather than being frustrated or disgusted by strange things, Susan now views them opportunistically, as fodder for her writing.



The scattered petals return; later, Mr. Foe will agree with Susan that there is something important to Friday’s psyche in this scattering. Yet fascinatingly, while Susan acknowledges that Friday’s life would make for a deeper and more compelling story, she does not attempt to write it—in part because she cannot seem to acknowledge that slavery is at the root of so many of Friday’s tragedies.



Just as Cruso paints Friday as a cannibal and himself as Friday’s helpless victim, Susan uses her power—her control over the story—to pretend weakness. By shifting the narrative of who is the enslaved and who is the enslaver, Susan both justifies and perpetuates her power.



In this crucial passage, Susan begins to blur the lines between art and artifice. By comparing herself to a painter, Susan gives herself license to rearrange timelines and pick and choose how to represent status (which is particularly salient given her relationship with Friday). But while a painter does not necessarily claim to be an accurate representative of reality, Susan’s narrative will appeal to people because it presents itself as the truth—so in filling the narrative with “painterly” embellishments, Susan is making a lie out of her own history.



Susan and the girl who claims to be her daughter venture into the forest together, reflecting that they are both “substantial beings.” When they are far away from any city or town, Susan begins to tell the girl about her true “parentage”; Susan claims Mr. Foe is the girl’s father, though the girl protests strongly. When the girl begs to know her true mother, Susan tells her that she is “father-born,” a phrase that shocks them both.

Time is now blurring as Susan writes a new letter to Mr. Foe. This time, she tells him that Friday has discovered his robes and wigs, which suggest that Mr. Foe belongs to a guild of some kind. Friday has taken to putting on the clothes and dancing, humming in a way that makes him seem “not himself.” Susan vows that she will not disrupt Friday during his dancing as long as he does his chores.

Still, it is getting easier to write, even though nothing seems to be happening. Susan tells Mr. Foe that she has started taking some of his household objects to sell, so that she can support herself and Friday. To go to market, Susan wears a robe belonging to someone named MJ (but who is that?); she looks much older than she used to. Susan imagines a shopkeeper ravaging her and thinks about her real daughter back in Brazil.

In another letter, Susan admits that she now understands why Mr. Foe was so eager to have cannibals be a part of their story; more words can be “sucked from a cannibal feast” than from more regular routines. Susan begins to study Friday as he eats and dances, imagining him as a cannibal until a shiver goes down her spine. There is “no doubt,” she writes, that his thoughts are on his flesh-eating past in such moments.

One day, Susan finds a chest of old recorders of different sizes; did Mr. Foe used to play these with his wife and child? Friday gets his hands on the instrument, and he teaches himself the same 6 note melody he used to play when Crusoe was so sick. In a desperate bid to communicate with Friday, Susan teaches herself the same song on a different recorder and plays it alongside him.

For an hour, Susan feels that music—like language or lovemaking—might actually allow her to connect to Friday. But soon enough, she grows bored, just as she would saying the same words or engaging in the same sexual motions.

The term “father-born” suggests an inversion of the natural order (as it would have been understood in the era), but it also hints once again at the parallel between artistic creation and childbearing. If Foe wants to write this girl into his story, he will have to birth her—suggesting that giving life to a story is not so different from giving birth to an actual child.



The fact that Susan has stopped dating her letters shows just how much life in England is starting to take on the blurry, out-of-time contours of life on the island. Again, Susan ignores one of Friday’s forms of expression (in this case, dancing) in favor of ordering him around.



Even though Susan becomes interested in the mystery of MJ, this passage shows how many of her own “mysteries” she is refusing to explore: she complains about not knowing Friday’s sexual past, but why do readers never learn about her own carnal desires (not to mention her mysterious daughter)?



By using the word “sucked,” Coetzee creates a clear parallel between the physical act of cannibalism and the narrative cannibalism that Susan is engaging in—she is taking other peoples’ stories as her own, just as cannibals take others’ flesh into their own bodies. By falsely suggesting that Friday is a cannibal, then, Susan is—ironically—engaging in an act of cannibalism herself.



This strange moment represents perhaps the only time in the entire novel where Susan authentically tries to connect with Friday. But even as she learns this song, Susan also disparages it, noting over and over how simplistic and unpleasant it is.



If childbirth is akin to novelistic creation, then it makes sense that Susan compares sexual congress with the artistic process. It is also clear, in this moment, how little Susan is actually willing to invest in communicating with Friday.



Susan tries to mix things up by playing another tune alongside Friday's original one, but he refuses to budge, and the two songs sound jarring together. Susan grows angry, feeling that Friday has never listened to her at all, "his soul more in Africa than in Newington." She thinks about what might happen if she hit him, but she does not actually do so.

In her next letter (still undated), Susan announces to Mr. Foe that she has created and signed a deed of freedom for Friday. Susan laments that she feels like Cruso's widow, and she informs Mr. Foe that she and Friday are on the road to Bristol, having left London.

Friday is dressed in Mr. Foe's wig, and Susan in her old sandals from the **island**, so they get lots of stares on the road. Each time, Susan explains that they were robbed by highwaymen on the way to her brother's house, but passers-by do not believe this story. Susan wonders if there are no more highwaymen, or if it is just something about her that makes people doubt her tale.

Susan stops at a cobbler and trades one of Mr. Foe's nicest books for a new pair of shoes. Susan worries that she will be assaulted, and she is not sure if Friday will do anything to protect her. Susan promises Friday that once they arrive in Bristol, a large port city, he will be able to get back to his family in Africa or Brazil.

At one point along their journey, Susan and Friday are stopped by a pair of drunken soldiers who attempt to rape Susan. Susan and Friday escape the soldiers, but get caught in the rain, and are forced to take shelter at a nearby tavern. When the innkeeper sees that Friday is not wearing shoes, he kicks them out of the establishment, humiliating Susan and stranding them in the wet darkness.

Susan and Friday find an empty barn, and Susan tries to use the hay as a blanket, but to no avail. Eventually, she starts doing Friday's dance just to keep herself warm—and it works. She reflects that she would never have learned why Friday did his dance if she had stayed at Mr. Foe's: "there is after all design in our lives," she decides. Susan continues the dance until she falls into a trance, imagining the other lives she might lead. When she finally comes back to reality, she is disappointed that she is still in the cold, on the road with Friday.

Just as her boredom makes Susan more willing to engage in fantasy, it also brings her more brutal impulses to the forefront. Though Susan does not want to identify as a slaveholder, she resembles one more and more.



Susan wants her decision to grant Friday freedom to seem generous. But as Mr. Foe will later acknowledge, even her assumption that she has the power to grant Friday freedom shows Susan's belief in the inherently flawed core principle of slavery: namely, the idea that one human being can own another.



Now, as she travels to Bristol (a city on England's western coast), Susan finds that her foray into storytelling does not stop at her writer's desk. Instead, she keeps narrating—and embellishing—at every step of her journey.



Susan's plan becomes clear: she wants not so much to free Friday as she does to free herself from any responsibility for him. But since she has no idea what country he comes from, much less the specific city or town, her plan to put Friday on some boat to somewhere is not thought through.



At this point, it is possible to doubt every chapter in Susan's surprisingly eventful story. Was she really nearly assaulted, or is she just adding color to her story? Susan has mused at length about the ease and profits of being an unreliable narrator—so why should anyone trust her now?



Susan previously dismissed Friday's dancing as meaningless and bizarre, but now she sees that it was actually logical. Susan's newfound desire to piece events together, giving this kind of logic and "design" to her life, reflects the lessons she has learned from her attempts at writing.



Susan tells Mr. Foe that she is not trying to make their journey more exciting than it really was—but one day, she notices a small bundle on the side of the road. When she unwraps the cloth, she discovers it is a bloody baby, stillborn or suffocated. Susan puts the baby down, not knowing what else to do, but she finds she cannot get her mind off of the child.

She begins to wonder if Friday might have eaten the baby if he'd gotten the chance, or if he might want to eat her; though part of her knows this is ridiculous, "another part, over which I had no mastery, insisted on his bloodlust." Susan starts feeling panicked by the fact that Friday's feet never get cold. She realizes that constantly, she is addressing her thoughts to Mr. Foe.

Susan is now in Marlborough, where she sells another of Mr. Foe's books (Pakenham's *Travels in Abyssinia*) to buy herself more stationary. In this new town, Susan and Friday are stopped by an old man, who is curious to know more about Friday. When Susan explains that he has no **tongue**, the man presses on, desperate to hear of the "sights" Friday has seen. He predicts that even if Friday were to tell his story, he would not be believed. Susan, creeped out by the man's behavior, hurries away with Friday in tow.

At last, Susan and Friday arrive at the Bristol port, which Friday seems to recognize. Susan meets with an Indian sailor in the hopes of finding a ship that will take Friday back to Africa, though when asked, she has no idea what part of Africa Friday comes from. The sailor brings Susan to his boss, who agrees to take Friday on board, much to Susan's relief.

As the arrangements get made, however, Susan begins to feel that all is not right; the ship captain's plan, she realizes, is to sell Friday into slavery again. Susan therefore backs out, and after she tries a couple of other sailors, all of whom are equally suspect, she comes to terms with the fact that her plan will not work. Susan feels she cannot possibly put Friday back into slavery; "I do not love him, but he is mine," she comments. "That is why he is in England. That is why he is here."

Susan claims to be telling the truth, so there are two possibilities: either Susan's journey is so eventful because she's lying, or she is just getting better at noticing and expanding on the juiciest anecdotes of daily life.



Just after claiming to be more honest, Susan's insidious invention comes to the fore. Horrifyingly, she starts to make Friday seem demonic, picturing him eating babies and suggesting that his feet never get cold (meaning that his body is somehow satanic, not human). Worst of all, Susan claims these thoughts are out of her control ("I had no mastery"), when in fact she has many times yearned to profit from such accusations.



It is ironic that Susan is bartering with another travel narrative to write her own; this trade suggests that these stories are perhaps more valuable to their authors than their readers. The interaction with the strange man shows how easily white English people exoticize Friday's Blackness—and though Susan is critical of this man, she is guilty of the same behavior.



Again, it is clear that Susan's plan to "free" Friday is based on her selfishness (and reveals her deep lack of thought and care about Friday's actual needs).



Susan differentiates herself from the captains who are so eager to sell Friday back into slavery—and there is a clear distinction between her life with Friday in London and the chattel slavery these captains want to profit from. But still, Susan's rhetoric reflects her belief in the fundamental logic of slavery: "he is mine," she declares in a sentence that she thinks displays her generosity but in fact shows her warped sense of power.



PART 3

Susan climbs the stairs, with Friday in tow, to Mr. Foe's new lodgings in Whitechapel. She is surprised to find that the apartment is so clean, when she was expecting it to be dusty—but then again, she muses, “life is never as we expect it to be.” She wonders if she will know how to recognize the afterlife when she arrives there; “after death we may find ourselves not among choirs of angels but in some quite ordinary place, as for instance a bath-house on a hot afternoon.”

Immediately, Susan presses Mr. Foe to say how the “history” of her and Cruso's time on the **island** is progressing. Mr. Foe replies that writing is slow, because it is “a slow story.” He asks Susan to give more details about her time in Bahia, but she is hesitant to do so, explaining that Bahia is not a part of the story she wants to tell. Nevertheless, she tells Mr. Foe a few details: about the city's system of cables and pulleys for shipping cargo, about the widespread presence of prostitutes, and about the variety of precious metals that are illegally trafficked.

Mr. Foe then asks Susan if Friday ever desired her, to which Susan responds, “how are we ever to know what goes on in the heart of Friday?” So Mr. Foe switches back to asking about Bahia, even though Susan protests that Bahia is “not the **island**” and therefore not worth Mr. Foe's time.

But now Mr. Foe reveals that he has a very different plan for the story in mind: to him, the story begins in London, with the kidnapping (or was it escape?) of Susan's daughter. His book will then follow Susan through her years in Bahia, before switching its focus to Susan's daughter, who has returned to Europe in search of her mother.

Foe continues his story: when the girl arrives back in Europe, she is sad to learn that Susan is nowhere to be found—until she hears about a female castaway, recently returned with a Black slave. “Loss, then quest, then recovery; beginning, then middle, then end,” Foe explains to Susan.

Months ago, Susan had marveled that reality was so like “the pictures we have in our minds”; now, she changes her tune, feeling that reality is untrustworthy. As someone preoccupied with gaining enduring fame and life through art, Susan now begins to wonder if eternity, too, will feel like the island—boring and repetitive and aimless.



For the first time in the novel, Susan is not the sole speaker—and so someone is there to challenge her omissions and contradictions. The use of the word “history” is also worth noting, as it implies that the story Foe and Susan are working on is strictly truthful—even though Susan has openly admitted to embellishing.



Mr. Foe is more curious about Friday's psyche than Susan is—but is his curiosity genuine, or does he just see Friday's story as a potential source of narrative profit?



Susan is determined to keep the focus on the island, but Foe does not seem interested in the island at all. While we never learn who wins this debate, the content of the real [Robinson Crusoe](#) suggests that Susan never gave any further details about Brazil; Defoe's real-life novel barely leaves the island (and does not touch at all on Susan's story).



Though Susan resents Foe for so blatantly trying to rewrite her history, he, too, is acting like a “painter,” rearranging or condensing events into a structure that is more convenient for him.



Susan begins to panic at this change to her own lived narrative, especially when Foe doubles down on his assertion that the **island** is not interesting on its own because it “lacks light and shade.” Frustrated, Susan replies that “the shadow whose lack you feel it is there: it is the loss of **Friday’s tongue**.” Following her own logic, Susan then concludes that the island story will not be complete until she somehow figures out how to give voice to Friday.

Susan then elaborates on the story of Friday’s dancing, confessing that she had omitted a key detail before: Friday is missing his actual tongue, but the word “**tongue**” is also a metaphor for Friday’s genitalia. Susan had long suspected that this might be the case, but her suspicions were confirmed when she came downstairs at Stoke Newington to see Friday dancing, bare naked save for his wig and his open robes.

Just as Cruso used more delicate terms to discuss this private mutilation, Susan surmises that Mr. Foe will have to use coded language (“figures”) in his book. Susan is disappointed in herself for sharing this detail; initially, she had vowed to keep some things to herself, but now she finds herself making “the darkest of confessions” to Mr. Foe, just like the ones she has read about in his narratives.

But Mr. Foe is still not satisfied, and still, he presses Susan to reveal more about Bahia; Susan compares him to a spider because of how patiently he waits for her to trap herself. But Susan refuses to do so, standing firm that the story of her lost daughter will not find its way into Mr. Foe’s book, just as she will not invent cannibals and pirates to break up the monotony of the island.

Moreover, Susan wants Mr. Foe to understand the difference between her silence and Friday’s silence. Because Friday has no words, Susan posits, he can be shaped into any narrative that is convenient; “I say he is a cannibal and he becomes a cannibal,” Susan decrees, “I say he is a laundryman and he becomes a laundryman.” By contrast, Susan’s silence is purposeful, a way of controlling her own narrative instead of surrendering it.

The painting metaphor continues in this discussion about light and shade. Interestingly, Susan can almost, but not entirely, admit the role that slavery plays in her story; though the brutality Friday has encountered casts a “shadow” over the whole story, Susan does not ever actually name the source of this shadow.



Now, again, it is difficult to tell whether Susan is lying or being truthful. On the one hand, it makes sense that she would find this information private and therefore inappropriate to share—but at the same time, if Friday is in fact missing his genitalia, why would Susan not have offered up that knowledge anytime a conversation about Friday’s sex life came up?



Another contradiction in the novel: at times, Susan presents herself as modest and proper, while at other times, she details her sexual exploits with detail and even relish. And indeed, Susan judges the scandalous heroes of Mr. Foe’s tales—but she also seems to have read every single tale with gusto.



Mr. Foe knows that boredom will lead to invention and confession; is he perhaps intentionally keeping Susan bored and in the dark, then, in the hopes that she will reveal more after weeks of monotony? There is also some irony in Susan’s claim that she will not invent cannibals, as she has made up several stories about Friday’s cannibalism.



In this vital exchange, Susan shows the immense power of language and storytelling—because Friday has no speech, she can invent his past and present, telling people stories that nobody is able to challenge. And just as there is power in sharing, there is also power in withholding—because she has a voice, Susan can both spread false stories and protest against true ones.



Besides, how could Susan describe Bahia to Mr. Foe even if she wanted to? Even just the list of pastries she encountered there is too long and varied to fit in a book, much less the complicated racial dynamics or the world of Brazil beyond Bahia's borders. Susan reflects that only small, boring places like the island can be "subjugated" into words.

Susan again insists that she is determined to be "father" to her own story. But Foe pushes back, using the example of a woman who, when sent to the gallows, confessed a stream of sins so endless that the chaplain finally made her stop talking. Susan wonders aloud if the moral of the story is that "he has the last word who disposes over the greatest force."

Mr. Foe tries to tell another parable, but Susan will not hear it. Instead, she loses her temper: though she once had dreams of being made famous as a castaway, now, she only hopes to feel like she is more special than an everyday servant.

Susan recounts the story of the ancient story of the Muse, "who visits poets in the night and begets stories upon them." At first, Susan wished that there could be a man-Muse to empower her, but now she sees that Mr. Foe is the "mother" of the story, while Susan's only job is to "beget" it. Foe listens carefully, but instead of responding, he merely offers Susan a fine Italian wafer from his alcove.

Susan compliments Mr. Foe on his lovely home and ponders whether her memoir was boring because the windowless room she wrote it in was boring. Mr. Foe reminds Susan that her story is boring because there are no adventures or cannibals to break it up. Susan answers that Friday is a cannibal, but that deprived of flesh, even cannibals can become boring.

Mr. Foe sends his servant-boy Jack out for dinner, informing Susan that he found Jack when the boy was out on the streets, pick-pocketing people. Susan wonders why Mr. Foe did not take Jack into his home as she has taken Friday into her life—but Mr. Foe replies that perhaps Friday might be happier were he able to find some of "his own kind." Susan thinks Friday might understand what Mr. Foe is saying, but she cannot be sure.

The use of the word "subjugated" is particularly worth noting, as it is Susan's most literal recognition of the power language has over places (and, by extension, the people within them). Moreover, remote islands are easier to subjugate than cities because there are fewer voices to contradict each other.



The word "father" reappears here—Susan distanced herself from the young girl by saying that she was "father-born," but Susan herself now claims to be a father of sorts. This essential conversation about "force" and language is, essentially, Susan's realization that history is written by the victors—and that people who use violence (like, for example, white enslavers) can rewrite narratives to help themselves.



Clearly, Susan's desire for fame and a literary legacy are so powerful that she would rather go hungry than go without prominence.



Susan now more explicitly plays with inverting gender roles. The word "beget" suggests that she will implant her story in Mr. Foe (acting in a phallic role), while he will carry it to term—acting as the story's pregnant "mother." Moreover, Susan wonders if the role of the Muse is also a masculine one, even though the Muse is a traditionally feminine figure; perhaps, then, Susan suggests that narrative is often a site of this kind of gender reversal.



On the one hand, Susan has fully committed to her false narrative of Friday's cannibalism. On the other hand, she finds that even this lie is not enough; if a story is based on adventure (as opposed to, say, interior life), it will always run out of steam.



In this debate over Jack and Friday, Foe begins to poke holes in Susan's paternalistic logic—is she sure she actually knows what Friday wants? Is her claim of responsibility for Friday as generous as she thinks it is, or is it more nefarious and self-serving?



Susan has a delicious meal with Friday and Mr. Foe. After they have finished, there is a knock on the door, and Foe opens it to reveal the young girl and Amy, the maid she claimed to have as a child in Deptford. Susan is angry, and she wants to leave immediately—"I am not a story," she tells Mr. Foe, and she vows that there are parts of her life and history which she will keep private.

Desperate to prove Foe wrong, Susan takes the girl in her arms and kisses her; the girl returns her kiss almost like a "lover." Yet Susan remains positive that the girl is not her daughter, and she grows ever more certain that Mr. Foe has sent them. Worse still, Susan now begins to doubt her own reality, and Mr. Foe's, a thought process she describes out loud: "now all my life grows to be story and there is nothing of my own left to me."

Instead of answering Susan, Mr. Foe kisses her passionately, and she kisses him back. After they embrace, Susan recalls a ghost story Mr. Foe had written several years before; the story feels like proof, to Susan, that merely talking or kissing someone is not enough to determine they are not a ghost.

Mr. Foe advises Susan to do as he does: every time he embarks on a new story, he leaves himself a marker of some kind, a certainty he can return to when he gets lost in "the maze of doubting." With those words, he dismisses Jack, and Amy and the girl (reluctantly) also leave Foe's house and return home.

Susan motions to leave, but Mr. Foe insists that she and Friday spend the night with him. Foe prepares an alcove for Friday to sleep in, but he invites Susan into his bed. Before they sleep, the two lie awake talking about their dreams and memories. Foe mentions an old Italian book where a man visits Hell and is greeted by ghosts. Foe quotes one of the ghosts from the book: "do not suppose, mortal," the ghost says, "that because I am not substantial these tears you behold are not the tears of true grief."

Susan now recounts the story of her first meeting with Foe, while he begins to touch her and flirt with her. As the two start to have sex, Susan is reminded of Cruso, and she closes her eyes, trying to imagine the **island**. But Susan cannot conjure that memory, so instead, she straddles Mr. Foe, whispering that this is how the Muse visits poets; "she must do whatever lies in her power to father her offspring," Susan explains.

Earlier, Susan bragged to Friday that she can decide, just with the force of her words, whether he is a "laundryman" or a "cannibal." But when Mr. Foe tries to transform her own life in a similar way, Susan refuses, insisting that her life is too real and meaningful to be "a story"—implicating, therefore, that Friday's life is not as meaningful.



In some ways, Susan's waning grasp of reality is karmic and of her own making; after all, she has spent so much time embellishing that now she does not know what she can trust. Susan's determination to preserve her privacy is especially interesting given how much she airs Friday's most private details.



Susan frequently frets about who is a "substantial being." This discussion of ghosts opens and complicates that question: is a real person defined by their words (narrative) or by their bodies (sex, contact, and kissing)?



Mr. Foe does seem genuinely interested in helping Susan become a better writer, suggesting that he feels less anxiety than Susan does about sharing narrative power.



The old Italian book Foe is referencing is Dante's famous [Inferno](#). But rather than simplifying Susan's problems with storytelling, Foe uses Dante to add another wrench in the mix—what happens to the characters and "ghosts" who are written off as insubstantial?



The novel has frequently conflated sex and artistic creation, but now Susan sees sex not just as symbolically related to authorship but as an important tool to preserve her story. Fascinatingly, Susan sees herself as the "father" here, suggesting that even if the young girl is "father-born," she could still be Susan's daughter.



After they have had sex, Foe begins to wonder about Friday throwing petals in the water back on the **island**. Maybe he was trying to appease a kraken, a giant sea monster. Or maybe he was visiting the ruined ship, which Foe thinks was actually a slave ship—so Friday would have been throwing petals to commemorate his dead loved ones.

Foe remarks that it is strange that Friday, despite being on the rough seas, survived his precarious petal throwing. Foe believes that in order to access the true story, they must learn Friday's perspective: "in every story there is a silence," Foe comments, and "we must make Friday's silence speak." But this upsets Susan, who feels that she has tried every way possible of getting Friday to speak—and has failed in all of them.

Foe suggests that Friday should try writing; after all, he has fingers. Foe also wonders if God did not speak the world into existence but rather wrote it into existence (and could be still writing it). Susan feels that Friday will not be able to understand the meanings of words, much less write them down, but she gives up trying to argue with Cruso.

That night, Susan struggles to asleep. In the middle of the night, she gets up and goes to the alcove, looking in at Friday. She cannot tell if Friday is asleep or awake, and when she crawls back into bed, she is disturbed by his presence. Fortunately, she is able to fall asleep soon.

The next morning, Susan and Friday are about to leave Mr. Foe's house. But before they can, Foe gives Susan a chalkboard and instructs her to teach Friday how to write. Using some money Mr. Foe gives her for breakfast, Susan and Friday eat, and then Susan begins to teach Friday the word house. She draws a picture, then writes the word beneath it, and encourages Friday to write the same word; he does, though his letters are misshapen.

Next, Susan teaches Friday the words "mother," "ship," and "Africa," using the same method; for "Africa," Susan draws a picture of palm trees and a lion. Friday shows no real signs of understanding, and Susan wonders if, privately, he is mocking her. Nevertheless, she returns to Mr. Foe, ready to demonstrate what Friday has learned.

In this vital passage, Foe closely examines what Susan has tried so hard to keep hidden: that Friday was being shipped into chattel slavery, and that Cruso, as a white man on the ship, was almost certainly a slave trader. Friday's oft-discussed "sorrows" are tremendous and multifaceted, and his only companion on the island is the very man responsible for the tragedies that have befallen him.



This belief that there is a whole story in the "silences" of traditional narratives emphasizes Coetzee's central artistic project and reflects a postmodern, postcolonial approach. Since erasure was such a big part of colonialism and enslavement, finding what has been obscured is a necessary part of trying to address those harms through art and literature.



Religion and faith play a giant role in [Robinson Crusoe](#) but have been almost entirely absent from Susan's own narrative. Perhaps this is because Susan wants to act as her own god, writing her island world into existence just as Foe speculates the biblical god might have done with the entire universe.



In her newfound discomfort, Susan seems to be suddenly aware of Friday's own consciousness, as distinct from (and potentially challenging to) her own.



Susan and Friday have been staying in Mr. Foe's various houses, so Susan has had access to slate and chalk for months. The fact that she has never before tried to teach Friday how to write, and that she does so now only for Mr. Foe's money, reveals again just how little she has actually invested in communicating with Friday.



Just as with her drawings about the loss of Friday's tongue, Susan's depiction of Africa is so riddled with stereotypes and assumptions that it ceases to be useful.



When they get to Foe's house, Friday takes the slate—but instead of writing on it, he draws a picture of human feet, each one covered by an eye. Susan tries to show the slate to Mr. Foe, but Friday spits on his fingers and erases his drawing. Susan despairs, comparing her situation with Friday to the tale of Sinbad of Persia. In that story, Sinbad offers help to an old man, only to find that the old man will cling to him forever and never let him go.

Foe pushes back on this—Friday's silence makes him easier for Foe and Susan to use as they wish, as they can imagine Friday's desires to be whatever is convenient for them. Susan insists that she knows what Friday is thinking, which is that he wants to be "liberated." But while Susan goes on a tangent about the true meaning of the word freedom, Foe believes the solution is more straightforward; the first step to liberating Friday will be to teach him to write some basic words, rather than debating the meaning of more nebulous language.

Susan still feels that teaching Friday to write is pointless, as he will just continue to follow her around. In response, Mr. Foe compares Susan to a slaveowner: "Friday follows you," he points out, "you do not follow Friday." Susan resents this suggestion, but on a walk by herself a few hours later, Susan cannot help but wonder if she is holding Friday "captive" to her desire for a good story.

And if Friday is a captive, could Foe also be a captive to the various people he writes about? Susan now begins to realize that, despite the scandalous stories in Foe's books, he is really writing the same story "over and over, in version after version, stillborn every time: the story of the **island**," which is "lifeless" no matter who writes it.

When Susan returns to Mr. Foe's house, the man sitting at the desk is not Foe—it is Friday, dressed in Foe's robes and wig and writing on Foe's papers. Susan is horrified by this, but she manages to sit down by Foe and Friday and watch as Friday tries to write.

There are several things worth noting in this strange excerpt. First, Friday's drawing perhaps shows how much those who are dismissed as servants ("hands") are actually constantly watching and interpreting (eyes). But also, Susan is once again rewriting history to position herself as the victim and slave instead as the victimizer.



Perhaps because Foe himself is a writer of dubious tales, he is hyper-attuned to how deceptive and tricky language can be. And indeed, Susan's prose-like, circular logic has thus far distracted her readers from the brutal truths at the heart of her tale. In other words, just as language can invert roles (turning Susan into a victim and Foe into a mother), it can also delay necessary action.



Here and elsewhere, Foe acts as a corrective to Susan's attempt at victimizing herself. But while Susan at last uses the language of slavery for herself, acknowledging that she is holding Friday in a kind of bondage, Foe is not a hero, either; the real [Robinson Crusoe](#) novel indulges in the mythos around Friday's cannibalism and writes slavery out of the narrative entirely. (Indeed, Friday is depicted as indigenous in Defoe's real novel).



Susan now begins to realize that readers' expectations and stereotypes dictate every story; what matters for money and success is not the truth, but simply what will please audiences. The use of the word "stillborn" again blurs the line between storytelling and conception.



It is worth taking extra note of the shift in genre now—as the novel comes to a close, Coetzee becomes more surreal in his writing, calling his readers' reality into question just as Susan begins to doubt her own circumstances.



In the daylight, Foe is very unattractive to Susan; noticing her distaste, Foe compares himself to “an old whore” who should only be seen in the dark. Susan instead compares Foe to a wife, because he is giving her a home and carrying her story—her child—to term. The mention of childbirth brings Foe back to Bahia, and Susan’s daughter there. And just as they are about to reignite the debate about the young girl who claims to be Susan’s child, Foe notices that Friday is writing the letter “o” over and over again. “Tomorrow,” Foe instructs Susan, “you must teach him ‘a.’”

Maybe the most unreliable thing about Susan as a narrator is her daughter: is Mr. Foe inventing this daughter, or is Susan just using words like “father-born” to distance herself from a child who is, in fact, hers? But rather than illuminating this tangential mystery, Foe is now clear about what is at the heart of the story—Friday’s thoughts, Friday’s perspective.



PART 4

A narrator—is it Susan?—climbs a set of dark steps, perhaps the same steps that lead to Foe’s attic room. On the steps there is a girl with a scarf wrapped around her head. But when the narrator unwraps the scarf, she is frightened to realize that there is actually nothing underneath it.

The radical shift in perspective and tone is meant to disorient readers. For so long, Susan has been in control of the story, but now it is not clear who is narrating; stylistically, too, the writing begins to feel more contemporary and less mannered. The girl on the steps seems to be the young girl who claims to be Susan’s daughter—and her lack of substance suggests that the narrator does not see the girl as “a substantial being,” to use Susan’s phrase.



The narrator enters the room at the top of the steps and sees a woman and a man in bed. The narrator expects that the two figures might be decayed, but in fact, their bodies are perfectly preserved. The narrator then opens the curtain to the alcove and sees “the man Friday” stretched out on his back. Friday is breathing softly, and his teeth are clenched; the narrator pries a finger in his mouth in an attempt to separate his teeth. After a long time, Friday’s lips part—and “from his mouth, without a breath, issue the sounds of the island.”

Again, time is losing its shape and structure—the two figures in bed are clearly Susan and Mr. Foe, but the circumstances surrounding this scene remain hazy. Crucially, though, even in this funhouse version of Mr. Foe’s house, Friday’s speech is both elusive and necessary—only he, this section of the book seems to agree, can bear witness to the real “sounds of the island.”



The same scene happens again: a narrator climbs the stairs of a house, though this time, the house explicitly belongs to “Daniel Defoe, author.” The narrator again stumbles past the body, “light as straw,” of a young girl; again, the narrator sees a man and a woman in bed together. This time, the narrator observes there is a scar on Friday’s neck, “left by a rope or a chain.”

This circling, repetitive climbing of the steps is typical of postmodernism, which works to engage readers and break down their expectations for a linear narrative. The repeated motif ties back to the beginning of Part Three, when Susan climbs the stairs to greet Mr. Foe—so is Susan narrating? But if this narrator is Susan, why are they pointing out the scar on Friday’s neck? The scar is a clear acknowledgement of the violence of slavery (which Susan tries so hard to obscure).



The narrator finds the first few sentences of Susan Barton's manuscript, which are familiar because those were the first couple sentences in the novel. But now, instead of going on to the **island**, the narrator ducks beneath the surface of the sea, where they are quickly covered in a mass of petals and where they see the wreck of Friday and Cruso's ship. The narrator brushes past something soft, which could be a shark or a dead body.

Inside the ship, the narrator comes to the top of a staircase and opens the door; it is not the "country bath-house" that Susan had once imagined eternity to be. Inside, there is black water for ages, "the same water as yesterday, as last year, as three hundred years ago." Susan Barton and the murdered captain are here, as is Friday. The narrator tries to speak to Friday, but underwater, speech is impossible.

The narrator again tries to open Friday's mouth so that he will speak. But instead of words, a "slow stream" comes out, pushing through the shipwreck and across all the cliffs and beaches of the **island**. The narrator, still unnamed, ends their tale by describing Friday's stream: "soft and cold, dark and unending, it beats against my eyelids, against the skin of my face."

Coetzee now makes literal the idea of going beneath a story's surface. Unlike the manuscript Susan Barton left, this new narration is more interested in exploration, in diving deep. And of course, the thing literally beneath the surface here is the massive loss and death on the slave ship—symbolizing, perhaps, the inarticulable tragedy of slavery.



Once again, this unnamed narrator shows traces of sharing Susan's consciousness—one reading of this scene might be that Susan is in the afterlife and that the afterlife is the ocean. Even in eternity, monotony is inescapable, suggesting that Susan's routine lives on both the island and in England are not the exception but the rule. And if Susan Barton is dead on the side of the ship, that suggests that this new narrator is a different—perhaps less literal—figure.



In some ways, Friday's story becomes like the ocean—vast, unknowable, and filled with both power and loss. Maybe this narrator is Coetzee or his readers or all of the generations that have followed Friday's story, all of whom must feel the "beating" of the "unending" stories erased from colonial histories.





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